

INTJ

PREMIUM PROFILE



16 Personalities

What Will You Find in This Profile?

This profile is designed to cover all the main aspects of your personality and areas of your life – your type description, relationships, academic path, career and professional development, your communication and friend-making skills, parenting tips and advice, and much, much more. It combines the personality type theory with practical, real-world advice coming directly from other people who share your personality type.

Personality types have been the topic of many discussions, some of them dating back to ancient times – it is wise to draw from that source of knowledge and experience, especially when you are unsure how to handle a particular situation. This kind of knowledge gives you a lot of power – the power to control and understand yourself. As Aristotle said millennia ago, “the hardest victory is the victory over self”. Consider this profile your battle plan.

What Does It Mean to Be an INTJ?

• • •

INTJs belong to the **Analyst** type group, along with ENTJs, ENTPs and INTPs. They have an Introverted, Intuitive, Thinking and Judging personality:

Introverted – INTJs listen carefully, prefer solitary activities, feel more comfortable when alone than when around other people and get exhausted by social interaction.

Intuitive – INTJs are introspective, rely on their imagination, are absorbed in ideas and focus on what might happen as opposed to what is happening or has already happened.

Thinking – INTJs are tough, follow their minds, suppress their feelings and emotions, and focus on objectivity and rationality.

Judging – INTJs are decisive, prefer clear rules, respect deadlines, are eager to commit and seek closure.

All Analysts prefer ideas to facts and focus on whatever works best.

Table of Contents

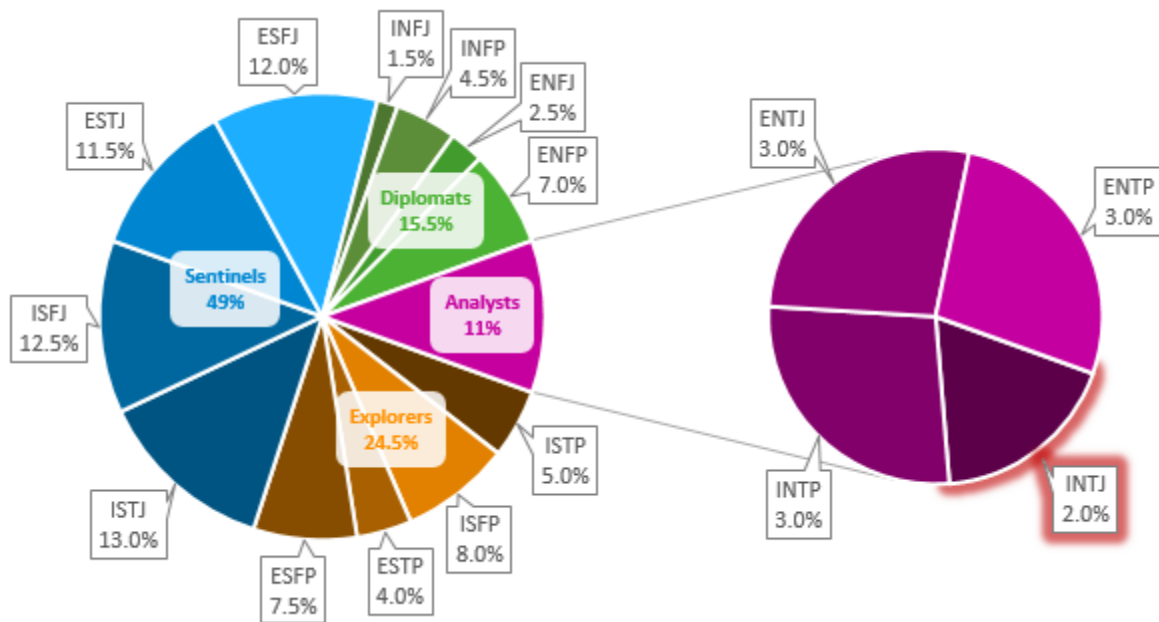
What Will You Find in This Profile?	1
INTJ Personality Type.....	5
INTJ Type Traits	10
Mind: Introverted vs. Extraverted.....	10
Energy: Intuitive vs. Observant.....	11
Nature: Thinking vs. Feeling	12
Tactics: Judging vs. Prospecting.....	13
Identity: Assertive vs. Turbulent.....	14
The Four Type Groups.....	15
Analysts (INTJs, INTPs, ENTJs and ENTPs)	15
Diplomats (INFJs, INFPs, ENFJs and ENFPs)	15
Sentinels (ISTJs, ISFJs, ESTJs and ESFJs)	15
Explorers (ISTPs, ISFPs, ESTPs and ESFPs)	16
INTJ Strengths and Weaknesses.....	17
INTJ Strengths.....	17
INTJ Weaknesses	19
INTJ Motivation and Self-Esteem.....	21
INTJs' Self-Esteem	21
INTJs' Self-Respect	23
INTJs' Self-Confidence.....	24
INTJs and Emotions	25
Personal Growth.....	27

What Things Cause the Most Problems for INTJs?	27
How to Make Good Use of INTJ Traits	31
Your Dark Side.....	34
Emotional Stability	36
Romantic Relationships	38
Potential Pairings.....	41
An Introverted (I) Partner	41
An Extraverted (E) Partner.....	43
An Intuitive (N) Partner	45
An Observant (S) Partner	46
A Thinking (T) Partner.....	48
A Feeling (F) Partner	49
A Judging (J) Partner.....	51
A Prospecting (P) Partner.....	52
Assertive or Turbulent?	54
Friendships	59
Parenthood	61
Academic Path	63
How INTJs Learn.....	63
INTJs in High School.....	64
Work or College?	67
When INTJs go to College	67
Career and Professional Development.....	70
Getting on the Career Ladder	71

Professional Development	74
Communication between Types.....	78
Analysts – Analysts	78
Analysts – Diplomats	81
Analysts – Sentinels.....	83
Analysts – Explorers.....	86
Career Progression	88
Alternative Options.....	89
Suitable Careers	90
What Would Make a Job Unsuitable for an INTJ?	93
Workplace Habits	94
INTJ Colleagues	94
INTJ Managers	95
INTJ Subordinates	95
What Do Other INTJs Say?.....	96

INTJ Personality Type

The INTJ personality type is one of the rarest and most interesting types. Only about 2% of Americans are believed to be INTJs – averaging 3.5-4% among men and 0.5-1% among women. These percentages seem to vary across regions – for instance, countries in Asia tend to have higher percentages of Introverted and Thinking types, with locations like Hong Kong or Singapore also leaning toward a higher number of Intuitive individuals. Furthermore, INTJs are significantly overrepresented in the virtual world, often accounting for 25% or more of the participants in a specific forum or a community site (e.g. Reddit.com).



INTJs are often seen as both highly intelligent and perplexingly mysterious. Idealistic visionaries, unemotional robots, brilliant strategists, socially awkward geeks, fearsome debaters – these are just a few examples of the numerous labels that INTJs seem to be able to get. There is usually little middle ground with strongly expressed INTJ personalities – other types either find their quirkiness mysterious and attractive, or feel uncomfortable and get offended. The INTJs themselves are either proud of their traits and wear them like a badge, or see themselves as eccentrics and do their best to mimic the behavior of other people, trying to blend in. These attitudes soften as people grow and develop, but they tend to be very black-and-white at a younger age.

Like other Analysts, INTJs radiate self-confidence, relying on their huge archive of knowledge spanning many different topics and areas. INTJs usually begin to develop that knowledge in early childhood (the “bookworm” nickname is quite common among them) and keep on doing that later on in life. People with this personality type tend to lean toward scientific or technological subjects, but there are plenty of exceptions – INTJs’ skills can be applied successfully in many different fields, as long as they have an opportunity to devise and improve some kind of a system.

When someone with the INTJ personality has mastered their chosen area of knowledge, they can quickly and honestly say whether they know the answer to a specific question. INTJs know what they know, and more importantly, they are confident in that knowledge. People with this personality type tend to firmly believe that they are intelligent and capable of many things, and sometimes this is a self-fulfilling prophecy. INTJs see no reason why they should not feel smart and act as if they are smart, knowing that there have been many occasions where their conclusions were proven correct.

Unsurprisingly, this personality type can be labelled as the most independent of all types. INTJs are very decisive, original, and insightful; these traits push other people to accept the INTJ’s ideas simply because of that sheer willpower and self-confidence. However, INTJ personalities do not seek nor enjoy the spotlight and may often decide to keep their opinions to themselves if the topic of discussion does not interest them that much or if they believe that their contribution would not make any difference. INTJs also expect everyone to be able to make their own decisions and are unlikely to try to manipulate or control other people, unless absolutely necessary.

INTJs are usually brutally honest, direct and rational. They will say what they really think and give solutions that they believe are right, even if that advice may not be appreciated by another person. An INTJ is unlikely to sugarcoat their words and questions; if they need something, they will ask directly instead of trying to “lead” or manipulate another person. Furthermore, they absolutely love biting and dark humor. There is no joke that an INTJ cannot handle.

INTJ personalities are perfectionists and they enjoy improving ideas and systems they come in contact with. As INTJs are naturally curious, this tends to happen quite frequently. However, they always try to remain in the rational territory no matter how attractive the end goal is. Every idea that is generated by

the INTJ's mind or reaches it from the outside needs to pass the cold-blooded filter called "Is this going to work?" This is the INTJs' coping mechanism, and they are notorious for applying it all the time, questioning everything and everyone. INTJs are not impressed by someone's title or social standing; they will not accept an idea simply because of its author's status.

Likewise, people with this personality type tend to have little patience with rules that make no sense to them. While some other types would happily accept the argument that things have always been done in this way, INTJs would question and challenge the existing procedures. This is one of the reasons why INTJs may have difficulties finding satisfaction in corporate or other highly structured and hierarchical environments, e.g. military. They may force themselves to follow orders and do what others expect them to do, but the growing discomfort and feeling of inauthenticity may eventually convince the INTJ to explore other possibilities.

INTJ personalities also have an unusual combination of both decisiveness and vivid imagination. What this means in practice is that they can both design a brilliant plan and execute it. Imagine a giant chess board where the pieces are constantly moving, trying out new tactics, always directed by an unseen hand. This is what the INTJ's imagination is like. An INTJ would assess all possible situations, calculate strategic and tactical moves, and more often than not develop a contingency plan or two as well. If someone with the INTJ personality type starts working with a new system, they will regard the task as a moral obligation, merging their perfectionism and drive into one formidable force. An INTJ will likely immediately and permanently lose respect for anyone who does not have enough talent or simply does not see the point, including the higher ranks of management.



INTJ personalities also often shoulder the burden of making important decisions without consulting their peers. They are natural leaders and excellent strategists, but they willingly give way to others vying for a leadership position, usually people with Extroverted (E) personality types. However, such action can be deceptive and maybe even calculated. An INTJ will retreat into the shadows, maintaining their grip on the most important decisions, and as soon as the leader fails and there is a need to take the steering

wheel, the INTJ will not hesitate to act, maybe even while staying in the background. The INTJ personality is the ultimate “man behind the curtain.”

INTJs dislike rules and artificial limitations; everything should be questionable and open to reevaluation. They may be idealists (impossible is nothing) and cynics (everybody lies) at the same time. Whatever the circumstances, you can always rely on the INTJ to “fill in” the gaps in an idea. They are most likely to come up with an unorthodox solution.

Generally speaking, INTJs prefer to work in the area they know very well. Their typical career is related to science, project management, strategy, or engineering, but they can be found anywhere there is a need for intelligence, a restless mind, and insight (e.g., law, investigations, and some academic fields). INTJ personalities rarely seek managerial positions; if they do, this is probably because they need more power and freedom of action, not because they enjoy managing people.

Every personality type has many weak spots and INTJs are not an exception. There is one area where their brilliant mind often becomes completely useless and may even hinder their efforts: INTJs find it very difficult to handle romantic relationships, especially in their earliest stages. People with this personality type are more than capable of loving and taking care of the people close to them, but they are likely to be completely clueless when it comes to attracting a partner.

The main reason behind this is that INTJ personalities are both private and incredibly rational. They find it very difficult to understand the complex social rituals that are considered part of the dating game, especially in Western societies. Things like flirting or small talk are unnatural to them; furthermore, INTJs (especially women) tend to see typical attraction tactics, such as feigning disinterest, as incredibly stupid and irrational. Ironically, INTJs are most likely to attract a partner when they stop looking for them; this is when their self-confidence starts shining again. There are few things that are more attractive than the unrelenting self-confidence that INTJs are known for.

Some famous INTJs:

- Vladimir Putin, President of Russia
- Augustus Caesar, Roman emperor

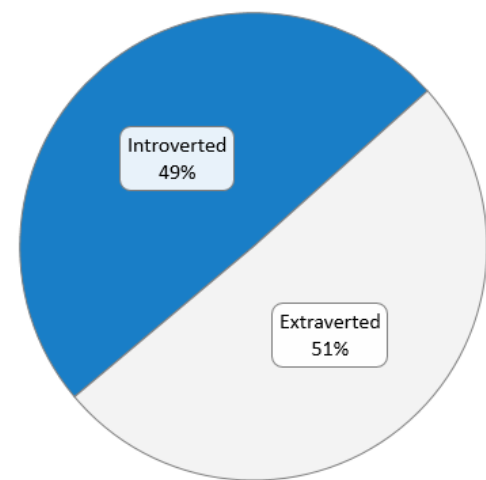
- Paul Krugman, famous American economist
- Rudy Giuliani, former New York mayor
- Donald Rumsfeld, former U.S. Secretary of Defense
- Colin Powell, former U.S. Secretary of State
- Samantha Power, diplomat
- Lance Armstrong, bicyclist
- Richard Gere, actor
- Hannibal, military leader of Carthage
- Arnold Schwarzenegger, actor and former California governor
- Thomas Jefferson, former U.S. president
- John F. Kennedy, former U.S. president
- Woodrow Wilson, former U.S. president
- “Walter White” (“Heisenberg”) from *Breaking Bad*
- “Gandalf the Grey” from *The Lord of the Rings*
- “Katniss Everdeen” from *The Hunger Games*
- “Hannibal” and “Clarice Starling” from *Silence of the Lambs*
- “Professor Moriarty,” Sherlock Holmes’ enemy
- “Gregory House” from *House M.D.*

INTJ Type Traits

While you have already seen the short description of all INTJ type traits at the beginning of this profile, this topic deserves to be covered in greater depth. Let us take a look at each trait and discuss how exactly it shapes your personality – but please bear in mind that this is just a generic overview. You may ask “so what am I supposed to do about this?” every once in a while – do not worry, we will get back to these topics in the personal development section.

Mind: Introverted vs. Extraverted

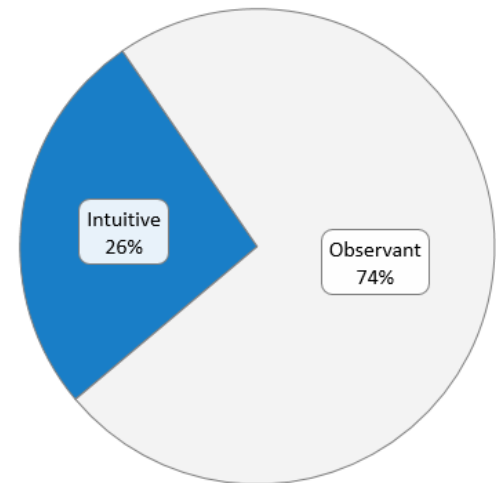
It is safe to say that this is probably the oldest notion in the history of personality theories. It has long been observed that some people are expressive, outgoing and comfortable in social situations – while others are reserved, quiet and more comfortable alone. It is as if the former (Extraverted individuals) sincerely enjoy engaging with the external world and recharge by communicating with other people, and the latter (Introverted individuals) prefer to rely on themselves and their own inner world instead of seeking stimulation from the outside. However, being Extraverted does not necessarily imply that the person will be an excellent public speaker; likewise, being Introverted does not mean that the individual is bound to be clumsy or antisocial. Rather, this trait shows the average degree of expressiveness and the overall tendency to seek stimulation from one or the other source.



INTJs are Introverted – this is why they are usually self-sufficient, have little desire to make plenty of friends, prefer working with systems rather than people, and have relatively poor social skills. Again, these are just tendencies and likely consequences, not black-and-white, unchangeable traits. For instance, INTJs are perfectly capable of honing their social skills and becoming experts in negotiation or small talk – however, these skills would be used out of necessity, not because the INTJ finds them natural or exciting. Socializing depletes INTJs’ internal energy reserves quite quickly and they always need to be able to return to their home base to recharge when that happens.

Energy: Intuitive vs. Observant

All personality types can be divided into two groups – those of the Intuitive energy style (more interested in ideas, focusing on the inner world) and those of the Observant energy style (more interested in facts and observable things, focusing on the external world). In our opinion, this dichotomy is the most important – while the other three determine how you interact with others (Introverted / Extraverted), make decisions (Thinking / Feeling) and schedule your activities (Judging / Prospecting), the chasm between Intuitive and Observant individuals is far more significant as it actually determines how you see the world and what kind of information you focus on.



Individuals with the Intuitive preference prioritize introspection, relying on their imagination, ideas and theories. They dream, fantasize and question why things happen the way they do, always feeling slightly detached from the actual, concrete world. One could even say that these individuals never actually feel as if they truly belong to this world. They may observe other people and events, but their minds remain directed inwards – always questioning, wondering and making connections.

In contrast, individuals with the Observant trait focus on the actual world. They enjoy seeing, touching, feeling and experiencing things – and leave theories to others. They always want to keep their feet on the ground and focus on the present instead of wondering why or when something might happen. Consequently, people with this preference tend to be better at dealing with facts, tools and concrete objects as opposed to introspecting or theorizing.

These traits determine the communication style as well – Intuitive individuals talk about ideas and have no difficulties with allusions or reading between the lines, while Observant types focus on facts and practical matters. This is why Intuitive types are likely to find it quite challenging to understand someone with the Observant trait, maybe even thinking that the latter is materialistic, unimaginative and simplistic. Likewise, an Observant individual is likely to think that their Intuitive conversation partner

is impractical, naïve and unobservant. Both sets of assumptions can be quite damaging and it takes a mature person to get past them – but statements like these are fairly common.

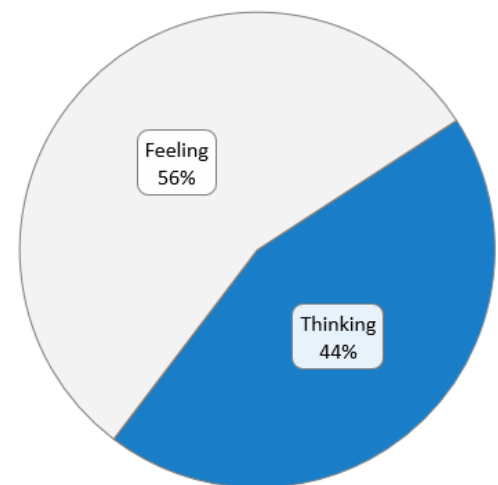
INTJs are Intuitive individuals – this is why they are so good at coming up with plans, strategies and ideas. People with this personality type spend far more time engaging in various internal discussions than observing concrete things around them. INTJs are not that concerned about what *is* happening – they focus on what *might* happen or *why* something has happened. This is the skill INTJs keep improving throughout their lives, which makes them bright and imaginative thinkers.

Of course, every stick has two ends. Introspection comes at a cost – by directing all their mental resources inwards, INTJs inevitably have to discard the information that is being provided by their senses. They are likely to have difficulties dealing with concrete, practical matters, or managing large collections of facts – even missing things happening right under their nose if they are not paying attention. This is also one of the reasons why INTJs tend to have so many difficulties finding a partner – as the majority of the population have the Observant trait, people with this personality type often find it very challenging to connect with others.

Nature: Thinking vs. Feeling

This trait determines how we make decisions and cope with emotions. People with the Thinking preference seek logic and rational arguments, relying on their head rather than their heart. They also do their best to safeguard their emotions, shielding them from the outside world and making sure that they are not clearly visible. “Whatever happens, you must always keep a cool head” – this is their motto.

In contrast, people with the Feeling preference follow their hearts and emotions and care little about hiding them. From their perspective, we should not be afraid to listen to our innermost feelings and share them with the world – these individuals tend to be compassionate, sensitive and highly emotional.

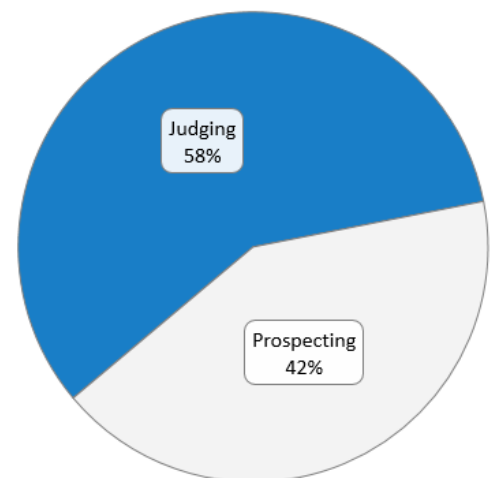


That being said, it is important not to make the mistake of thinking that the first group is cold-blooded and indifferent, and that the second one is sentimental and irrational. This is a false dichotomy – Thinking types are often just as emotional as Feeling types, they simply try to hide and suppress their emotions; and Feeling individuals are fully capable of being rational, although they are likely to use different arguments, putting compassion and cooperation above logic and hard facts. It is unreasonable to dismiss or disparage either of these perspectives – both are perfectly valid.

INTJs belong to the Thinking group – they trust and prioritize logic, relying on rational arguments and doing everything they can to keep their true feelings and emotions deep below the surface. As already mentioned in the previous section, people with this personality type are renowned for their use of the “is this going to work?” filter regardless of the circumstances – an INTJ will question everything, starting with their teachers’ methods and ending with the prospects of their romantic relationships. The Intuitive and Thinking traits form the core of the INTJ personality, making them highly intelligent, open-minded and utilitarian individuals, capable of amazing intellectual feats, especially in scientific or technological fields. However, they also push INTJs away from the majority of the population, making it difficult for them to relate to other people, especially when it comes to handling emotions.

Tactics: Judging vs. Prospecting

This set of traits determines how we approach planning and available options. People with the Judging preference do not like to keep their options open – they would rather come up with five different contingency plans than just go ahead and deal with the challenges as they come. They prefer clarity and closure, always going with the plan rather than the flow. Furthermore, these individuals also tend to have a very strong work ethic, putting their duties and responsibilities above everything else.



In contrast, Prospecting individuals are always scanning for opportunities and options, willing to jump at them at a moment's notice. People with this preference are perfectly aware that life is full of possibilities and are reluctant to commit to something that might well prove to be an inferior option in

the future. They are also likely to focus more on what makes them happy as opposed to what their parents, employers, teachers etc. expect – if a specific task is not that important or interesting, a Prospecting individual will always be able to come up with something better to do.

INTJs are Judging individuals – they are decisive, do not tolerate inefficiency and usually find it difficult to cope with uncertainty. This is what makes them excellent strategists, both willing and able to dedicate time to devising complex plans. That being said, people with this personality type are not as meticulous or rule-bound as Sentinels – they seek closure, but do not obsess over tiny details or procedures. INTJs are strategists rather than logisticians.

Identity: Assertive vs. Turbulent

You may have noticed that we did not highlight either of these options, unlike before – this is because this particular trait affects all others, showing how confident you are in your abilities and decisions. Assertive individuals are emotionally stable, calm, relaxed and refuse to worry too much about minor matters. In contrast, individuals with the Turbulent identity tend to care about their image, be self-conscious, success-driven and perfectionists. This does not necessarily mean that having an Assertive identity is better – for instance, Turbulent individuals perform better in certain roles as they push themselves to achieve superior results, while Assertive ones do not care about the outcome that much. However, Assertive individuals tend to benefit from higher emotional stability and increased self-confidence.

The Four Type Groups

Key traits discussed above are paired to form the four Type Groups. Each of the four groups covers a set of personality types that are very similar; we will use these groups later in this profile to draw contrasts and similarities between personalities. They also serve to highlight the importance we have placed on the Energy trait – each personality type will share either the Observant or the Intuitive trait with all other members of their group, as well as one other key trait.

Analysts (INTJs, INTPs, ENTJs and ENTPs)

These Intuitive and Thinking personality types embrace rationality and impartiality, excelling in intellectual debates and scientific or technological fields. They are fiercely independent, open-minded, strong-willed and imaginative, approaching many things from a utilitarian perspective and being far more interested in what works than what satisfies everybody. These traits make Analysts excellent strategic thinkers, but also cause difficulties when it comes to social or romantic pursuits.

Diplomats (INFJs, INFPs, ENFJs and ENFPs)

A group of Intuitive and Feeling personality types – Diplomats focus on empathy and cooperation, shining in diplomacy and counselling. People belonging to this type group are cooperative and imaginative, often playing the role of harmonizers in their workplace or social circles. These traits make Diplomats warm, empathic and influential individuals, but also cause issues when there is a need to rely exclusively on cold rationality or make difficult decisions.

Sentinels (ISTJs, ISFJs, ESTJs and ESFJs)

We call Observant and Judging personality types Sentinels – they are cooperative and highly practical, embracing and creating order, security and stability wherever they go. People belonging to one of these types tend to be hard working, meticulous and traditional, and excel in logistical or administrative fields, especially those that rely on clear hierarchies and rules. These personality types stick to their plans and do not shy away from difficult tasks – however, they can also be very inflexible and reluctant to accept different points of view.

Explorers (ISTPs, ISFPs, ESTPs and ESFPs)

These Observant and Prospecting personality types are the most spontaneous of all, and they also share the ability to connect with their surroundings in a way that is beyond the reach of other types. Explorers are utilitarian and practical, shining in situations that require quick reaction and the ability to think on their feet. They are masters of tools and techniques, using them in many different ways – ranging from mastering physical tools to convincing other people. Unsurprisingly, these personality types are irreplaceable in crises, crafts and sales – however, their traits can also push them toward undertaking risky endeavors or focusing solely on sensual pleasures.

INTJ Strengths and Weaknesses

INTJs are the ultimate analysts and strategists, usually surpassing all other personality types when it comes to processing the available data quickly and objectively, and then making a logical choice. This trait can be both their greatest advantage and the most difficult obstacle, depending on the situation – as life itself is not always logical, INTJs need to learn how to combine their intellectual prowess with the skills they must have in order to succeed in life.



The biggest problem for INTJs is that they can often be too confident in their analytical abilities. Being used to seeing their logical conclusions proven right over and over again, INTJs are prone to developing a sort of tunnel vision and strong sense of superiority when it comes to non-scientific matters. There are many situations in life where the logical choice is the wrong one or where the second best option beats the first one – and INTJs may find it very hard to accept such notions.

There is no other type that is more likely to believe that they have a superior mind and to see other people as inferior, irrational human beings. However, there is also no other type that is as capable of ripping something apart, analyzing the contents and then constructing a better version of the initial object – be it a project, a theory, or their own personality. If they see a good enough reason, INTJs have an amazing capacity to improve themselves – but they need to understand what their strengths and weaknesses are and where they stem from.

INTJ Strengths

- **High self-confidence.** INTJ personalities rarely doubt themselves or care much about their perceived social roles, expectations etc. Consequently, they are not afraid to voice their own opinions. This exudes confidence and reinforces the INTJ's self-esteem even further.

- **Quick and versatile mind.** INTJs are very good at improving their knowledge of (often diverse) topics and fields that interest them. People with this personality type take pleasure in tackling intellectual challenges and their natural curiosity pushes them forward as well.
- **Jacks-of-all-trades.** The most important strength of any INTJ is their mind. Other personality types pride themselves on being artistic, empathic, convincing, athletic, etc. In contrast, INTJs excel at being able to analyze anything that life throws at them, uncovering the underlying methodology and then applying it in practice. Consequently, INTJ personalities are usually able to become what they want to become—be it an IT architect or a high-flying politician.
- **Independent and decisive.** People with the INTJ personality type are ruthless when it comes to analyzing the usefulness of methods or ideas. They could not care less if that idea is popular or supported by an authority figure. If the INTJ believes that it does not make sense, only overwhelming rational arguments will convince them otherwise. This strength makes them efficient and impartial decision-makers, often at a very young age. INTJs also tend to be quite resistant to conflicts, usually remaining rational and calm in an emotionally charged situation.
- **Hard-working and determined.** INTJ personalities can be very patient and dedicated if something excites or intrigues them. They will work hard to achieve their goals, often ignoring everything else. That being said, INTJs may also appear lazy in situations that do not require them to flex their mental muscles. For instance, they may take risks and not study that hard at school, knowing that in all likelihood, they will be able to tackle the tests anyway.
- **Imaginative and strategic.** INTJs are very good strategic thinkers, often using this strength to devise multiple contingency plans in both professional and personal situations. They like to plan ahead and be prepared, imagining all the potential scenarios and consequences.
- **Honest and direct.** People with this personality type hate playing social games and putting comfort or social expectations above honesty and facts. INTJs tend to see these activities as pointless and irrational, preferring inconvenient truth over a comforting lie.
- **Open-minded.** INTJ personalities do not mind being proven wrong and enjoy being exposed to something they were not familiar with. They will embrace a competing theory if it makes more sense, regardless of the existing traditions or expectations. Not surprisingly, INTJs also tend to be

fairly liberal in a social sense, believing that many social norms are outdated and unnecessarily restrictive.

INTJ Weaknesses

- **Arrogant.** There is a fine line between confidence and arrogance. Some less mature INTJs may overestimate the importance of their knowledge or analytical skills, seeing most other people as irrational or intellectually inferior, often making their opinion known.
- **Perfectionists.** INTJ personalities loathe inefficiency and imperfection, trying very hard to iron out all the flaws and to analyze all the possibilities. If left unchecked, this trait can easily become a weakness, significantly slowing down their work and frustrating the people around them.
- **Likely to overanalyze everything.** INTJs tend to believe that everything can be analyzed, even things that are not necessarily rational – e.g. human relationships. They may seek logical explanations and solutions in every situation, refusing to rely on improvisation or their own emotions.
- **Judgmental.** INTJs reach their conclusions very quickly and stick to them. Even though people with this personality type tend to be open-minded, they have little patience for things they consider illogical, e.g., decisions based on feelings, irrational stubbornness, emotional outbursts, etc. An INTJ is likely to believe that someone who behaves in this way is either very immature or irrational; consequently, they will have little respect for them.
- **May be insensitive.** INTJ personalities often pride themselves on being brutally honest and logical. However, while their statements may be rational and completely correct, they may not take into account another person's emotional state, background, individual circumstances, etc. Consequently, the INTJ's directness and honesty may easily hurt other people, thus becoming a major weakness in social situations.
- **Often clueless when it comes to romantic relationships.** Many INTJs are likely to have difficulties dealing with anything that does not require logical reasoning and this weakness is especially visible in interpersonal relationships. They may overanalyze everything, get frustrated trying to understand how the other person thinks, try to use a nearly scientific approach to dating, or just give up altogether.

- **Loathe highly structured environments.** INTJ personalities do not respect rules or regulations just because they are there; they need to be confident that those restrictions make sense. Consequently, INTJs strongly dislike environments that are built on blind obedience, traditions or respect for authority. They are likely to challenge the status quo and clash with people who prefer stability and safety.

INTJ Motivation and Self-Esteem

Closely related but different, your self-esteem, self-respect and self-confidence are the sources of your motivation. Self-esteem speaks to your sense of your own worth. Self-respect speaks to how much you like yourself. Self-confidence is where you find the energy that moves you forward in your life. Much of our core motivation comes from trying to successfully satisfy these core aspects of ourselves. Think of them as three powerful psychological engines that, when understood and harnessed, can lead to a successful and fulfilling life.

However, like anything in life, if you allow these engines to overwhelm you, they can also be a source of great difficulty. Think of it like an engine overheating. This is usually caused because something in our psychological make-up needs support, and so we overcompensate to gird that which feels weak to us. If for some reason we're not feeling self-confident, we might pour on the thing that gives us confidence. The problem is that sometimes we crank it up too high trying to compensate.

The first section in each part represents the tendencies in their healthy form. When people use these motivators in a balanced way, they can help them be productive and happy. This represents the ideal expression of the motivator.

The second represents tendencies to watch out for if the engine begins to overheat. The purpose is not to describe anyone specifically. The descriptions in the second part may sound extreme, and they probably are for most INTJs and other Analysts. People generally exist at different degrees somewhere between fully this and fully that. Life has a way of socializing us and balancing us regardless of our foundational traits. When reading the second part, think in terms of tendencies and regard it more as a cautionary tale.

Self-improvement is about stepping outside one's comfort zone to expand your life for the better. The third section suggests a simple way to get along more effectively in the world through some simple rebalancing exercise.

INTJs' Self-Esteem

INTJs base their sense of self-worth on their resourcefulness. Being able to use their agile minds to figure out what is what and find effective solutions makes them feel they are at their best. INTJs are often

knowledgeable and can perform like a walking search engine. They often have all the pertinent facts at their fingertips. Combining their preference for intuition and thinking, they can deftly put facts together in a logical and useful way.

Since this is such an integral part of their identity, it's natural that they measure their worth by how they see their resourcefulness. Preserving this resourcefulness is the basic motivator in their lives. INTJs like to come across as experts who know how to apply facts and logic and as the person to go to if you need to make sense of anything. They can be most helpful in untangling complex problems and helping to discover solutions.

When the quest for self-esteem goes out of balance: INTJs are not the most social people from any perspective. They can be awkward, condescending, and abrasive. They often believe what goes on in their heads is more important than the people around them.

If they need to strengthen their sense of self-worth, their resourcefulness can overheat and transform into arrogance. The INTJs may begin to believe their own press. They may place their own ideas and solutions above the opinions of others. It's not a matter of the press not being true. It's just sometimes ingredients other than logic can sometimes contribute to the right decision.

INTJs run the risk of discounting the contributions of others, damaging both social and career satisfaction and advancement. Condescension is not pretty, and nobody likes a know-it-all.

Self-esteem rebalanced: To rebalance, INTJs may do well to use their analytical tools in a way that mimics empathy. Empathy doesn't come naturally to them and clearly isn't a strong point. Think Sheldon Cooper on "The Big Bang Theory" as an extreme example. Instead of trying to identify with others' feelings, INTJs might learn what that looks like and note how others respond to the world.

For the INTJ, learning to deal with the other character types might take an intellectual exercise akin to visiting a foreign culture. While you may not necessarily "go native" when you visit a different culture, you try to respect their way of life. You become an observer and learn the language and the customs to get along in the new setting. An anthropologist might relish the opportunity to learn about the culture.

INTJs can do something similar. Playing the mental game of “anthropologist”, they can try to understand enough to take on repairing any alienation they might have created. It’s just a matter of deliberately channeling their analytical skills in a socially healthy direction. Learning the 16 personalities and their variants can be useful for this.

INTJs’ Self-Respect

INTJs respect themselves when they have a sense they are being independent. They like to keep their own counsel as they navigate the world using their ideas and heavy-duty thinking as much as possible. That’s when they feel that they are at their best. INTJs interpret doing otherwise as being dependent. Depending on someone else’s ideas or conclusions is not nearly as satisfying. This motivator can lead down the “road less traveled” and that, in turn, can lead to fresh perspectives that can be useful and even revolutionary at times. INTJs’ agile minds can see what others miss, and when this occurs, it can be a powerful point of pride and self-respect for this personality type.

When the quest for self-respect gets out of balance: “Overheated” INTJs may go so rogue that they come to disdain necessary structures that support their academic or career goals. They can take their loathing for conformity to an extreme and this can make them useless to an organization and simply unpleasant in most other ways. This is especially true if the system they’re bucking doesn’t mesh with their rational framework. If it doesn’t make sense to them, you can bet that they aren’t going to easily fall in line. To INTJs that is the worst kind of dependence. However, no person is an island, even if that person is an INTJ. An extreme belief in going it alone can seriously hamper success.

Self-respect rebalanced: The solution for the INTJ will always be to return to their intellect and their world of ideas. For them, rebalancing extreme independence might mean learning to accept the idea there is such a thing as “healthy opportunism”. Logically, they don’t have to accept or agree with the principles of an organization or a social structure to benefit from it.

The question INTJs might seriously ask when at odds with an idea or philosophy, “What can I get from this? How can this help me advance?” It sounds manipulative, but that’s because it is. Aren’t we all just trying to get our needs met? Why shouldn’t the INTJs put their skills to good use? Certainly, with the resourcefulness of the INTJs, they can figure out a way to make any system work for them if they need

to. That's independent thinking. And who knows? By "playing the game", they may genuinely soften and expand their comfort zone to the point where they begin to understand the viewpoints of others.

INTJs' Self-Confidence

INTJs move forward relying on their willpower. They have to believe that their will is strong enough to enable them to tackle any challenge that comes their way. They mostly trust their own thoughts and ideas, so they need to feel the locus of control is coming from inside them to confidently move forward. If that is where your trust lies, who else is there? And a strong-willed person with right values and insight can change the world.

When the quest for self-confidence gets out of control: When they invest too much in their own willpower, INTJs may lose confidence in areas of their lives where that control means little. Sexual feelings are not always rational. Emotions will not always comply with how we want to feel at a particular time. Even if we adopt healthiest lifestyle habits, sometimes we get sick anyway. Other people will refuse to take direction no matter how much we feel that they should. People we care about die and there's nothing we can do about it. When it becomes clear that their willpower can be useless in a certain situation, INTJs may feel lost. It might even cause a fear reaction and result in inappropriate behavior in their attempt to regain confidence. They may try to push through even though reality says they can't.

Self-confidence rebalanced: The Serenity Prayer, popularized by the many 12 Step programs, asks for divine help. It asks that God help the person praying to accept what he can't change, change what he can, and know the difference between the two. This is a great exercise for INTJs. Taking an inventory of these things and coming to grips with the undeniable truth that not everything will bend to their will may help INTJs preserve their peace of mind. While this will not be deeply satisfying to them, acceptance can help them adopt a perspective that, nonetheless, allows them to enjoy a certain level of serenity and confidence.

INTJs and Emotions

We would also like to spend some time covering the area that most INTJs are likely to find very problematic – handling feelings and emotions.

Most INTJ personalities pride themselves in remaining rational and logical at all times, seeing most emotional displays as a sign of weakness and irrationality. As people with this personality type also tend to be very honest and straightforward, it is no surprise that they are often seen as insensitive. Some INTJs may go even further, claiming that they have no feelings or emotions at all, and that anyone who does is weak and irrational.

Ironically, INTJs can be just as emotional, if not more so, than any other personality type. Everything depends on how we define and handle emotions – for instance, there is a world of difference between breaking down in public and simply being thoughtful or amused. For most INTJs, public displays of emotion are outside of their comfort zone and consequently they will do their best to restrain themselves. However, this does not mean that INTJs have no feelings – rather, they tend to be good at channeling their emotions and using logic to keep them in check.

One of the reasons behind the cold exterior is that people with the INTJ personality type tend to be very proud of their knowledge and abilities – revealing emotions or even acknowledging that they exist may be a frightening prospect, especially if the INTJ in question is younger and secretly not as confident as they would like to be. In such cases, the INTJ will shield themselves with coldness and logic, allowing their Thinking trait to act like a protective big brother to their emotions.

Second, logic and rationality play a dominant role in the INTJ decision-making process – feelings usually only come into play when their Thinking trait cannot come up with a rational solution to a difficult problem. To give an example, if an INTJ is upset, they will not need to tell everyone around them that they are upset – on the contrary, they will focus on identifying why they are upset and then coming up with a logical solution to their problems. Alternatively, they will channel that energy into something productive.

That being said, emotions will always influence the decisions that the INTJ is making, at least to some extent – it is impossible to separate the two, even though most people with the INTJ personality type try hard to make decisions and solve problems without involving their feelings. How we process is also how we feel, and how we feel is also how we process – this applies to INTJs as well. However, people with this personality type find it quite easy to deal with those emotions internally, without exposing them to the outside world, and this is why they may radiate that aura of logic and detachment.

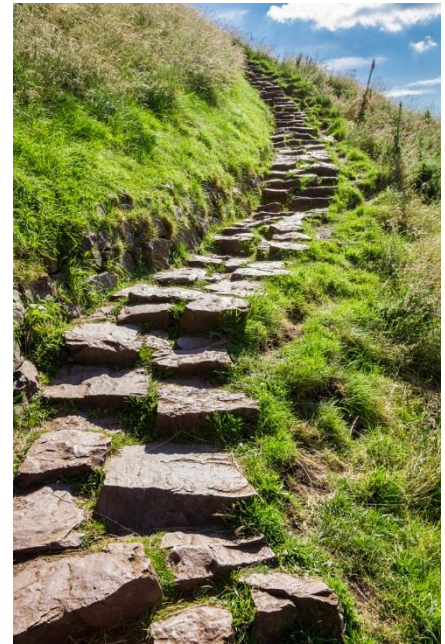
The point is, INTJ personalities can be very sensitive and have very deep feelings. Even though these emotions will be shielded from the public view by their Thinking trait and will (usually) not be the deciding factor in the INTJ decision-making process, this does not mean that INTJs should be seen as, or should aspire to be, cold-blooded and insensitive geniuses living by the mantra that emotions are for the weak. This is not the case and is not going to happen.

Personal Growth

Knowing your strengths and weaknesses is great, but leveraging or addressing them is even better. Let us take a look at some of the ways to do that.

What Things Cause the Most Problems for INTJs?

INTJs are nearly immune to conflict and criticism, but only when they see such comments as rational. They will be more than happy to listen to alternative views and change their opinion if the opponent proves them wrong. The INTJ may even act as a devil's advocate themselves if something seems like an interesting idea. However, any argument the INTJ sees as irrational or coming from a person that they have not evaluated yet will likely be discarded straight away or, if the INTJ feels particularly charitable, ripped apart as illogical, statement by statement, and then handed back to the critic in pieces. As the INTJ mind is used to filtering out irrelevant information, it applies the same approach to criticism as well – and this is not always the best option.



INTJs should remember that every type has many weak spots and they are not an exception – INTJs tend to be quite perplexed when it comes to emotional matters and practical things such as fashion, sense of space, aesthetics etc. No matter how difficult it may be for an INTJ to accept this, there are many types that are much better at these things, even though they may not have the analytical abilities of the INTJ. People with this personality type are likely to feel quite vulnerable when such matters form the basis of a conflict with someone close to them. INTJs should consciously try to learn from this experience and explore such territory instead of raising their rationality shields and trying to stay in their comfort zone every time this happens.

As already mentioned, INTJs are also very confident in their abilities and knowledge. This is usually a very attractive trait which makes it easier to charm the opposite sex or get ahead on the career ladder.

However, an INTJ should make sure that such confidence does not come across as arrogance or condescension – this is a sure way to alienate other people. The INTJ's natural instinct in this situation is to assume that those individuals are less intelligent or rational and therefore unworthy of their attention – and this vicious circle is then completed by the INTJ concluding that they are, yet again, right but misunderstood by inferior minds. This prevents personal growth and development, severely limiting the INTJ's prospects. A mature and wise INTJ can achieve truly amazing things, but only if they recognize that their abilities and knowledge are not limitless.

It is also very important for an INTJ to accept the idea that their intellectual capacity can and will be enhanced as a result of consciously seeking opportunities to connect with and listen to other people. The one thing that all INTJs are afraid of is that something can compromise the integrity of their inner sanctum, that nucleus made of critical thinking, logic and knowledge. Of course, there needs to be an emotional distance between the INTJ and the environment – however, that sanctum is not at risk just because they spend some time listening to someone that lived in a different age, pursues a different dream or is not as experienced in the field of their interest. Confidence must not become a limiting factor and overshadow the curiosity – in the words of Socrates, “I know one thing, that I know nothing”.

As highly rational creatures, INTJs are likely to face many difficulties when it comes to emotions and sensitivity. They will find it quite problematic to both express and understand feelings – and this may cause significant problems in their relationships. An INTJ is likely to even take a certain pride in being unemotional, seeing feelings as illogical and contrasting them with rational thoughts. However, emotions form a crucial part of everyone's personality and consequently it is imperative to recognize their importance. It is a myth that INTJs do not have emotions – rather, the trait responsible for their expression and recognition is underdeveloped, giving way to rational thinking. This does not mean that INTJs are, or should aspire to be, cold-hearted robots shunning all emotional contact.

Rational thinking and unquenchable desire to improve things inevitably lead to another typical INTJ weakness – relentless perfectionism. This can be a great trait, but it often becomes disastrous in personal relationships, if the INTJ is unwilling or unable to control their mind. Neither the INTJ's partner nor the relationship itself will ever be perfect and it is crucial that the INTJ recognizes this and does not get lost in never-ending thoughts about how this and that could be improved. No matter how difficult this may

seem, INTJs need to learn how to live in the present when it comes to such situations, letting their mind rest and enjoying the experience rather than seeing the relationship as yet another personal improvement project. Furthermore, INTJs are prone to seeing so many opportunities around themselves that it may become very difficult to focus on one single goal.

INTJs tend to (and more often than not, need to) believe that that they are always right. Unlike some other personality types who base their self-esteem on material things, fame or number of Facebook friends, INTJs are often self-sufficient and can be perfectly happy being alone with their mind. That mind is their most precious gift and their most prized possession – consequently, INTJs can become very defensive when they sense that their conclusions may be wrong. This is a natural instinct, but such an approach can hinder personal growth and development, as well as endanger personal relationships. It would be good for INTJs to recognize that even they can make mistakes. Furthermore, the human mind is geared to seek facts that reinforce existing views and ideas – and even an INTJ can easily fall victim to this. INTJs need to understand that recognizing one's faults and limitations is the only path to personal growth – ego can be self-destructive, and people with this personality type are especially prone to this.

Another area that we should cover here is INTJs' social skills. This is one thing that always comes up in our surveys – many INTJs state outright that they have issues in this area. Let us first discuss why this happens.

All Analysts share the combination of Intuitive and Thinking traits, feeling most comfortable in the world of ideas and principles as opposed to facts and strictly down-to-earth, practical matters. This is why they dislike small talk – it forces Analysts to discuss topics that they are mostly unfamiliar with. Gossip, sports and various details of daily life (“Guess what I saw at the bus stop this morning...”) rarely interest people belonging to this type group – consequently, finding something to talk about can be a real challenge. While silence works well as a negotiation tactic, it makes most people really uncomfortable in casual conversations. Out of all Analysts, INTJs are the ones most likely to be hindered by this – people with this personality type are Introverted, which means that they are used to being alone and engaging in self-reflection as opposed to relying on external connections; and they also prefer Judging to Prospecting when it comes to tactics, which forces them to seek closure instead of simply going with the flow of conversation. The combination of all these traits makes it very difficult for most INTJs to engage in small

talk and leads to awkwardness in social situations, especially if the other person is not willing to take the lead. In turn, the INTJ may often experience anxiety well in advance of the social event, knowing that it is likely to be a challenge.

There are two things to be considered here. One is that the ability to make small talk can be developed just like any other skill. INTJs are good at coming up with strategies and there is no reason why small talk should not be approached just like any other challenge. There is plenty of advice available on the internet (for instance, [Lifehack](#) suggests focusing on F.O.R.M. – Family, Occupation, Recreation and Money), so we will not go into specifics here – however, it is worth pointing out that everything boils down to the fact that the main purpose of small talk is to serve as a gateway leading to a deeper, more meaningful conversation. It also has other uses, such as getting a quick glimpse into another person's personality and making them feel more important – so there are plenty of reasons why you should take time to develop this skill.

The second thing is that the ability to make small talk does not represent the entire spectrum of social skills. INTJs can be very eloquent and convincing when they are talking about something that greatly interests them – they are perfectly capable of painting an impressive picture with their words. Likewise, they are unlikely to have any difficulties keeping up their side of the conversation if they are talking with another like-minded Analyst. There is no reason to think that there is something wrong with you if you simply have poor small talk skills – in all likelihood, you have spent just a tiny amount of time practicing them, when compared to nearly any Extrovert. Of course you will be at a disadvantage. However, if you break this issue down into its basic building blocks and strategies, you will find that it is far less scary than it looks. Most people love talking about themselves, all they need is a little encouragement. For instance, simply try to listen to what they are saying and then ask some basic follow-up questions (e.g. “I was thinking about joining the Army, but went into hotel management instead”) leads to at least two questions – one about the Army, another one about hotels. Do not focus on what you are going to say next or think that you are obliged to immediately offer some information about yourself in return. There are plenty of things that make small talk much easier – just do the necessary research. This (and practice, of course) will make your life much easier in social situations.

Additionally, it is worth remembering that small talk is just the exterior layer, the tool that is used to ease into more serious topics. Knowing all the tips and strategies in the world will not help if you start feeling fidgety and anxious the moment someone asks you a question. If you are feeling really uncomfortable in social situations, your true self-confidence will show, and this is what you need to work on. It is often said that actual talking is just one part of the conversation, and a small one at that – your body language is far more critical. Let's illustrate the value of self-confidence with a quick example: imagine two well-dressed gentlemen in a high-end restaurant, both having chicken for dinner. One is anxiously trying to cut some meat off the bone using a fork and a knife, doing his best to maintain composure. The other one is completely relaxed and is simply holding the chicken drumstick with one of his hands. The latter will look infinitely better – you may wonder for a moment why he is eating this way in a really nice restaurant, but his calmness and self-confidence will be far more important than his use of utensils. The same applies to social situations – you need to know the basic techniques, but they will not really mean anything if your body language is screaming “I am uncomfortable”. It is very important to work on the presentation of self-confidence as well, especially if you are actively trying to meet new people, e.g. a potential partner. We have already covered this in the previous section – focus on things that make you tick and you should have no problems building your self-confidence.

Now that we have covered the main weaknesses of this personality type, let us move on to their strengths.

How to Make Good Use of INTJ Traits

The INTJ mind is at its best when it comes to analyzing tendencies and hidden meanings or devising unusual ways to achieve a specific goal. INTJs can process incoming information in a systematic way, quickly determining its usefulness and validity, and then placing that piece of the puzzle in the right drawer deep within their mind. This makes them excellent analysts and strategists, but there is one caveat. In order to achieve the full potential of their abilities, INTJs need to maintain a balance between their Intuitive and Thinking traits. Think of this in terms of checks and balances. Used properly, the Intuitive trait should be given the priority when it comes to generating ideas, but the Thinking trait should then step in and force the INTJ to make the decision and pick one idea, setting aside the others.

Similarly, the Thinking trait should be used to make decisions, provided that it also leaves enough room for the Intuitive trait that is responsible for coming up with fresh ideas.

INTJs can be very determined and passionate if they truly care about something. However, they should make a conscious effort to keep their mind focused on one project instead of jumping from one topic to another. The INTJ mind is not meant for routine things or following steps A, B, C, D... - it will jump from A to D, then back to C, then think of a better way to handle B and so on. It is important for an INTJ to keep this tendency in check in order to guarantee the project's success. As Thomas Edison (who is believed to have been an INTJ as well!) once said, "Genius is one percent inspiration, ninety nine percent perspiration." No matter how intelligent an INTJ is, their mind needs to stay on track, especially if that phase of the process is relatively dull.

It is also likely that an INTJ will be able to understand and utilize principles or ideas that would normally be considered to be beyond their intellectual capacity or knowledge. This may come as a pleasant surprise to an INTJ and provide an opportunity for significant personal growth – however, the only way to do this is to recognize that there is much to learn and then go into the uncharted territory. Even though INTJs tend to be very confident in their abilities, this naturally makes them reluctant to do things that might endanger that feeling – such as trying to learn something that is completely new to them. A growth-oriented INTJ should recognize this and overcome the powerlessness and frustration that often form part of the learning process. This will allow the INTJ to go above and beyond what other personality types can achieve.

INTJs tend to be very stable individuals, renowned for their ability to come up with numerous contingency plans for everything that could potentially go wrong in their lives. This makes people with this personality type surprisingly resilient, especially after they have been given an opportunity to build some kind of a safety net for themselves. And it is not just the professional life and financial standing that benefit from this – INTJs' stability and inherent self-confidence make them very attractive partners, especially after the tumultuous 18-25 year period. This is one of the reasons why younger "single and looking" INTJs should not worry too much if they are having difficulties finding a suitable partner – people's preferences change as they grow and mature, and INTJs' traits tend to only become more attractive over time.

Another thing that INTJs are known for is their sense of humor. People with this personality type can be really witty when they want to – thanks to their well-developed intuition, INTJs have no difficulties making mental connections and coming up with interesting retorts. INTJs are also masters of sarcasm and often take pleasure in seeing other people try to read between the lines and decipher their jokes. The INTJs' encyclopedic knowledge also tends to prove very useful in such situations, with the INTJ often coming up with a random, somewhat related fact that once again makes everyone else wonder why they happen to know that. This sense of humor can also be the INTJ's savior in situations where they are expected to relax and "have fun" – as other people are likely to nag the INTJ to come out of their shell, a little bit of self-deprecating humor will go a long way in such cases.

It is also fair to say that as an INTJ, you will likely have better critical thinking skills than most people you meet. The ability to self-reflect and analyze your own motives, decisions and mistakes is a great strength, and you should utilize it often. This is especially important when it comes to personal development – making goals for yourself and managing your ego is an excellent recipe for personal growth. However, it is just as important not to overthink things, especially where there is plenty of subjectivity involved. For instance, people's actions cannot always be explained with rational arguments, and this affects numerous other things in life. INTJs often find it hard to accept the notion of "going with the flow", but that is unavoidable in many situations. You will not be able to find objective answers to everything.

We will finish this section by pointing out that one of the most surprising (and inspiring) things about INTJs is that regardless of all their weak points, people with this personality type often say that they would not change one thing about themselves. INTJs know they are not perfect, but they are very good at drawing upon their inner strength and imagination. There are plenty of people who like to say that they would "fix" themselves in so many ways if they had a chance – this is not the case with INTJs. We have recently conducted a survey of 50+ INTJs, asking them what aspect of their personality they would change given a chance – and a striking majority of respondents stated that they would not change a thing or that they would simply like to learn how to use their gifts in a more effective way. Not a single INTJ stated that they would like to change something radical, in stark contrast with other personality types.

At first glance, this may seem arrogant – but it is in fact a perfectly sensible approach. INTJs like to explore everything – secrets of nature, wonders of technology, depths of their own mind – and more often than not they are able to find a way to improve things they do not like. Unsurprisingly, most INTJs are well aware of what their weaknesses are and they know how to address them, if necessary. Many even say that there is no such thing as a weakness, and that it is all a matter of perspective. And they are right – some people are better at certain things than others, but that does not mean that everyone should strive to be good at everything.

Most importantly, you need to be happy with yourself. Do not try to meet other people's expectations or work hard on developing traits that society says are valuable but that go against who you are. As you are probably well aware, INTJs (especially INTJ women) are really rare, so it is completely understandable that many of the things the wider society seems to value – such as seeking materialistic rewards, socializing, following the well-travelled path of study-work-buy a house etc. – may seem forced and unnatural to you. Society, especially in the Western world, is dominated by Observant types (especially Sentinels), who usually get to set the rules, determining which traits are considered strengths and which ones are seen as weaknesses. However, this does not mean that you need to change who you are in order to be successful – recognize your weak points, but do not try to mold your personality to suit someone else's expectations.

Your Dark Side

Each personality type has its dark side – it may emerge under extreme stress or fatigue, especially if the individual is frustrated by their real or perceived weaknesses. In those cases, their “evil twin” may manifest itself as the complete opposite of their personality, throwing the underdeveloped shadow traits into the light. Outwardly, it would seem as if the individual has suddenly decided to adopt a completely different approach to many things, including their career, romantic relationships, habits and so on. Inside, the individual is likely to feel confused and split between two completely different worldviews.

In some circumstances, such a change may not be sudden or short-lived – the individual may choose, either consciously or unconsciously, to behave in this way for a very long time if, for instance, they seek to fight their overly protective parents, restrictive environment, or bad memories. Some examples of such

behavior could be: an exemplary student leaving their parents' house and becoming a party animal in college; a sociable, friendly and sensitive guy purposefully isolating himself from the outside world and being obsessed by radical ideas after a senseless crime committed against his close friend; or a quiet, conservative girl suffering from a bad break-up suddenly becoming far more liberal, or embracing a completely different philosophy when it comes to choosing partners.

It is not impossible that the individual's social circle will encourage them as well, by complimenting the clearly visible changes, e.g. more spontaneity, sensitivity or willingness to take risks – this would also reassure the individual, maybe even leading them toward a conclusion that this is actually their “real” personality and their previous persona was just a repressed version of their “real” self.

INTJs are not an exception to this rule. Your “evil twin” would be an unhealthy version of the ESFP personality – it may push you toward things like emotional outbursts, caring deeply about your social status, engaging in pointless repetitive activities, befriending random strangers, drinking, gambling etc. This may even feel liberating at times – for instance, you may feel strangely energized by social interaction or risky decisions that pay off – but that state is likely to be short-lived, succeeded by feelings of emptiness and confusion.

In such circumstances, it is important to remember to stop and think hard about who you truly are and whether your behavior is a true reflection of your inner self, or only a temporary mirage created by your mind to serve some kind of purpose (e.g. to try something completely different). Do not think about what you *are* (an engineer, a nice guy or a brilliant student) – that is irrelevant. Rather, think about what you can *do*. Pick up a blank sheet of paper and a pen, sit down and try to think of your purpose in life, of something that you would really, really want to create, experience or achieve in 5, 10 or 20 years. Any random thought will do, just keep writing them all down. You will definitely know when you have hit the right one – it may even make you cry. That will be the definition and reflection of your true self.

Simply being familiar with the fact that each one of us has a dark side is a good thing – this will enable you to spot when that “switch” has happened, either within yourself or within someone close to you. Otherwise, you may be oblivious to what is going on and even think that it would be a good idea to shut down any doubts and simply “double up” on whatever you are doing, getting drawn deeper into the

never-ending spiral of cheating yourself. It is one thing to use and develop your weaker traits wisely – it is quite another to give in and let them lead the way completely unchallenged.

Emotional Stability

Another important area related to INTJs' personal growth is emotional stability. This is determined by the last trait that we discussed in the "INTJ Type Traits" section above (the "Identity" subsection) – you would have also seen your personal score after completing our personality test. There are two sides of the "Identity" scale:

- Assertive – people with the Assertive identity are emotionally stable, calm, relaxed and refuse to worry too much.
- Turbulent – people with the Turbulent identity are self-conscious, perfectionists, care about their image and tend to be success-driven.

Most individuals are close to the middle on this particular scale, although that depends on the social environment and sex of the individual. For instance, women tend to be further to the right side of the scale (i.e. more likely to have a Turbulent identity), although that varies from region to region – sex differences are negligible in Africa and Asia, but rather significant in the Western world.

If you are an Assertive INTJ, you are likely to be quite comfortable with your identity – you know what your strengths and weaknesses are, and do not hesitate to leverage them where possible. You may be relatively perfectionistic, but you do not go overboard with it, knowing that no one is perfect and no project is worth obsessing too much about. Similarly, you do not feel threatened by minor challenges, remaining calm and focused in stressful situations. All INTJs tend to be good at controlling their emotions, but Assertive INTJs go further, refusing to internalize them – this means that even deep down, they are not really affected by either negative or positive emotions. They rarely get stressed or excited, staying calm and composed at all times.

On the other hand, the Assertive identity is not always a positive thing. A certain level of self-consciousness or occasional "emotional rollercoasters" can be quite useful, especially from the personal development perspective – for instance, Assertive INTJs are likely to have a lower drive, and potentially

productivity, due to lower sensitivity to negative outcomes. People with this variant of the INTJ personality also tend to be more forceful and self-confident, which can isolate them from other people – it is important to remember that INTJs have a rather unique set of traits and skills, and these differences set them apart, even without taking Assertive identity into account.

In contrast, if you have a Turbulent identity, you are likely to be rather anxious about your performance and prone to worrying too much about the consequences of your actions. As an INTJ, you would still be rather confident in your abilities, knowing that you are a resourceful and knowledgeable individual – however, it is also likely that you would push yourself to the limit, internalizing all the stress and worry that would inevitably accompany your perfectionism. Deep down, you may also care about how other people perceive you (or how your ideal self would perceive you), even though you may do your best to not reveal that sensitive side of yours. This may lead to certain “emotional rollercoasters”, with you feeling at the top of the world when you see your plans coming nicely into fruition, and then plunging into the abyss when you are forced to face your weaknesses or when you feel lost or can no longer cope with the workload. Turbulent identity is inseparable from higher stress levels, which can also lead to health problems if left unaddressed.

Then again, there are certain advantages to having a Turbulent identity. For instance, it could be argued that because Turbulent INTJs are more success-driven and self-conscious than their Assertive cousins, they can also potentially achieve better results and become more well-rounded individuals instead of feeling satisfied with where and who they are.

Regardless of whether you are an Assertive or a Turbulent INTJ, everything depends on your willingness and ability to address the challenges posed by your identity type. Each side has its own advantages and disadvantages, although generally you should try to stay close to the middle of this scale in order to achieve optimal results and grow as an individual. If you have an Assertive identity, learn to recognize the benefits of setting more difficult goals for yourself and occasionally giving in to your emotions – they are an inseparable part of our lives and Assertive INTJs should not try to present themselves as highly intelligent yet completely unemotional. Similarly, if you have a Turbulent identity, learn how not to internalize stress or negative emotions, and do not see yourself as a superhuman who must always aim for the best and never fail.

Romantic Relationships



INTJ personalities are likely to have significant difficulties when it comes to relationships and dating. INTJs spend a large part of their lives in their heads; consequently what they see and understand intuitively can be much more advanced than a “bland” reality. As a result, someone with the INTJ personality may find it challenging to merge those fantasies and high requirements with reality. Unfortunately, their superior logic and imagination

may actually hinder the INTJ when they start looking for a partner.

People with this personality type are likely to apply a rational approach to dating and relationships as well. An INTJ is likely to have a “checklist” in their mind long before they actually start thinking about a relationship. It is also likely that “he/she must be rational” will be at the top of their list of criteria—and this is exactly what usually holds the INTJ back, especially if they are male. There are certain rules (e.g., do not appear too interested) and types of behavior (e.g., a girl should not start the conversation) that a person interested in finding a dating partner is expected to follow, and unfortunately for INTJs, the majority of people will follow those rules. Even those potential partners who an INTJ would normally see as rational will probably yield to societal expectations. Consequently, INTJs are likely to get quite disappointed after the first few attempts at dating and may even start thinking that the opposite sex is either irrational or intellectually inferior.

Paradoxically, people with the INTJ personality are most likely to attract a romantic partner when they are not actually looking for one. As most INTJs have difficulties with dating and relationships, their self-confidence takes a major hit in those situations, and they then overcompensate by showing off their intelligence, which makes them even more unattractive. Only when they return to their usual selves does their self-confidence start glowing again, which makes it much easier for them to attract a partner.

When dating, INTJs tend to always keep their eyes open, scanning the environment for potential mates, although their approach and criteria will likely be significantly different from the rest of the population. Many other types place a lot of importance on physical attractiveness, social status or communication skills when they try to determine whether someone would be a suitable mate. INTJs rarely care about these things. In contrast, they try to evaluate another person's intelligence, rationality and wisdom. They see right through the act, have no patience for individuals whom they perceive as shallow, and loathe dating games and "rules". Some INTJs may try to compensate for the poor social skills by throwing jokes, but more often than not they focus on intellectual or even scientific topics – after all, INTJs' knowledge and reasoning skills are nearly always miles ahead of social skills.

This is one of the main reasons why INTJs are often branded as picky and snobbish by people who are used to getting attention primarily because of their looks or social status, or cannot understand how the INTJ could remain rational while looking for a partner. INTJs tend to see dating as a way to find someone they could invest their time and effort in, someone that would understand and appreciate their ideas – most other types would find this very odd and unromantic. Furthermore, INTJ personalities often come up with lists of intellectual and physical traits they would like their partners to have or obtain, ticking boxes as the relationship progresses. The problem is that those requirements may be quite unrealistic, bearing in mind that INTJs often lack experience in this area – people with this personality type need to find the middle ground between having overly strict criteria and settling down with the first person who is interested in having a relationship with them.

INTJs are uncomfortable expressing their feelings or trying to understand the emotions of other people. They also have a tendency to always trust their knowledge and understanding. Not surprisingly, INTJs can sometimes inadvertently hurt other people, especially during the dating phase and even later in the relationship. The mind of the INTJ personality is geared toward looking at conflict situations as logical puzzles worthy of analysis, which does not always help when their relationship partner does not share the same notion of fun.

That being said, INTJs' feelings run very deep and can be very powerful – but they will be expressed in a way that will be very different from the usual cuddling, kissing and saying "I love you" every couple of minutes. They may do that as well, but only because they have learned this is expected, not because

they feel that way. Generally, INTJs tend to be wonderful mates – loyal, honest and always eager to work on improving the relationship.

In conflict situations, INTJs are likely to look for logical solutions and believe that every problem has a solution. They will approach the conflict from a rational perspective, try to understand what led to that situation, and then address the root cause. An INTJ will not jump in to offer emotional support though, unless they figure out that this is what they have to do to resolve the conflict.

Sexually, INTJs are likely to be very imaginative and enthusiastic, provided that their partner is willing to reciprocate. However, it is important that the INTJ does not fall into a habit of spending more time theorizing about intimacy than communicating with their partner. People with this personality type, especially female INTJs, need to feel that their mind is aroused just as much as their body in order to be fully stimulated – for INTJs, lack of intelligence tends to be a big turn-off, even if it is a one-time thing.

People with the INTJ personality type may terminate the relationship if they are confident that it is at risk of breaking down, and they will not look back. INTJs' approach to dating is quite similar: they will not keep trying if their mind is telling them that the likelihood of a strong relationship is very low. However, the calm exterior can be deceiving; it is more than likely that the INTJ will feel very hurt inside and spend extensive amounts of time figuring out what went wrong, especially if they had devoted a lot of time to dating or making the relationship work.

When it comes to break-ups, INTJs' ability to rationalize everything is both a blessing and a curse. If the INTJ believes that there was a clear reason behind a break-up, they will continue with their life quite easily, even though they may never forget the hurt. However, if the INTJ cannot find a rational explanation, this will be quite frustrating for them as they will assume that either their partner was irrational and all relationships are like that, or that they are not insightful enough to find the real reason behind the break-up.

INTJs are bewilderingly deep and intelligent people, bringing a lot of stability and insight into their romantic relationships, but as already mentioned, that extraordinary intelligence is their main enemy in this area. That being said, if both partners manage to survive the rocky start during the dating phase, it

is very likely that the relationship will be very deep and strong and the INTJ will do everything they can to ensure it stays that way, as long as the partner reciprocates.

Preferred partners: ENFP and ENTP types, as their Extraversion and Prospecting traits counterbalance INTJs' Introversion and Judging traits. INFJs are also a very strong match as the intuitive connection between INTJ and INFJ is likely to be instantaneous.

Potential Pairings

Let us now take a look at all potential trait pairings – this will help you understand how those combinations work in romantic relationships. Each combination of traits brings different things into the relationship, sometimes positive and sometimes negative – knowing what to expect will definitely help you further down the road. However, please remember that each individual is unique, and what



is true for one may not be true for another. Ultimately, you will be responsible for figuring out what exact role these traits play in your relationship.

An Introverted (I) Partner

The best thing about being in a relationship with another Introvert is that you both are likely to be entirely self-sufficient. Spending time alone is not going to scare you that much – nor would the idea of staying at home and doing something together instead of going out. You are not going to feel a strong need to be around other people – talking with your partner will suffice.

You will also be in a good position when it comes to resolving problems in a relationship. As Introverts, you will both be used to discussing something and then going through all the details in your mind, as opposed to dealing with it externally, i.e. by relying on the actual discussion process.

As Introverts, you will have been pushed to "go out and socialize" numerous times in your lives. This is not going to happen in your relationship – in all likelihood, having a couple of close friends will fulfill all your socialization needs.

On the other hand, this is what brings us to the next part, where we are going to talk about difficulties you are likely to face. As you are both going to be quite reserved, you will likely have a situation where neither partner is willing to step up and push the other to socialize – or take the lead in a social event that you cannot escape from (e.g. wedding of a relative). Despite being Introverts, you are going to need at least some socialization if you want to avoid feeling isolated. The fact that you both are used to dodging social interaction is going to make this difficult.

You may also have difficulties when it comes to resolving conflicts. As mentioned above, introspection is great when you are analyzing your mistakes – the problem is that you need to become aware of those mistakes to begin with. As you both are likely to keep your thoughts to yourselves instead of throwing them out in the open, you will probably encounter many situations where one of the partners is keeping their feelings of resentment inside, allowing them to build up, instead of talking about them. You will have to consciously work on improving your communication and get used to opening up.

Tips for both individuals:

1. **Be patient.** Your potential partner may need a lot of time to open up to you.
2. **When dating, choose locations without much social pressure.** Your potential partner may feel uncomfortable with many other people around.
3. **Do not overcompensate.** Small talk is unavoidable in the dating phase, but you are unlikely to be good at it. Do not overcompensate by trying to appear chatty and sociable or pushing your potential partner to talk. At best, you will look insecure and the other person will feel uncomfortable.
4. **Speak up.** Once you transition into a relationship, you will need to remind yourself to share your thoughts with your partner instead of sticking to your habit of keep everything to yourself. Communication is key in an Introvert- Introvert relationship.

5. **Do not get stuck in a bubble.** You may both have difficulties when it comes to socializing with other people. Make sure that you do not falsely reassure each other that such interaction is completely unnecessary, even though this may seem to be an easy option.

An Extraverted (E) Partner

The best thing about being in a relationship with someone who does not share your first trait is that you are going to balance each other out quite well. The Introvert will encourage the extravert to slow down and take a moment to think before acting, to spend more time reflecting on things before jumping straight into the action. The extravert, on the other hand, will draw the Introvert out from their shell, playing the role of the socializer in the relationship, encouraging their partner to establish new social links and taking care of any social obligations that the couple might have.

These differences will also be beneficial when it comes to resolving conflicts in the relationship. However, it is crucial that both partners are mature and willing to listen to each other instead of sticking to their own guns and refusing to accept different viewpoints most of the time. If all goes well, both partners will be able to cover each other's strengths and weaknesses.

That being said, each stick has two ends and personality differences may also have a negative impact on the stability and health of the relationship. If one (or both) of the partners is not very mature, they may have difficulties understanding the other person's perspective. In such circumstances, the extravert may get frustrated by the fact that their Introverted partner is more reserved and private, or has poor social skills. And vice versa, the Introvert may get annoyed by the extravert's chattiness or need to socialize.

It is crucial that both individuals make conscious efforts to understand each other; in all likelihood, they will both think that their way of life is perfectly normal and it is the other person who is strange. The fact that we tend to surround ourselves with friends who are like us is not going to help either – this simply reinforces our positive perception of ourselves along with the idea that our traits are the right ones. The only way to get out of that bubble is to push the limits and try to see the world through another person's eyes. When an Introvert and an Extravert form a relationship, they give each other an excellent opportunity to do just so.

Tips for you:

1. **Do not overcompensate.** Small talk is unavoidable in the dating phase, but you are unlikely to be good at it. Do not overcompensate by trying to appear chatty and sociable – let the extravert take the lead. Otherwise, you will simply look insecure.
2. **Speak up.** Once you transition into a relationship, you will need to remind yourself to share your thoughts with your partner instead of sticking to your habit of keep everything to yourself.
3. **Do not get stuck in a bubble.** You will likely have difficulties when it comes to socializing with other people. Your extraverted partner will probably take care of this in social situations, but that does not mean that you should not make conscious efforts to bring something to the conversation. Do not get lazy.
4. **Be tolerant.** Your partner is likely to have difficulties when it comes to understanding why you need to spend time alone instead of talking to them. They might also worry that they have done something to offend you – as extraverts recharge while spending time with other people, your partner may not know that you need exactly the opposite. Take your time to explain how your mind works.

Tips for your partner:

1. **Be patient.** Your potential partner may need a lot of time to open up to you.
2. **When dating, choose locations without much social pressure.** Your potential partner may feel uncomfortable with many other people around.
3. **Do not be overbearing.** Small talk is often a challenge for Introverts, even though it is unavoidable in the dating phase. Do not be overbearing by trying to get your potential partner to talk extensively about themselves. At best, they will feel uncomfortable.
4. **Be tolerant.** Your partner is likely to have difficulties when it comes to socializing with other people or even yourself for an extensive amount of time. Remember that they get exhausted by social interaction, unlike you, who are recharged by it. There will be times when they will want to be alone – be understanding, give them space and do not ask them what is wrong. This has nothing to do with you – your Introvert simply needs some time alone to recharge.

An Intuitive (N) Partner

As Intuitives, you are both likely to prefer introspection over observation – that is, you will spend more time exploring the world of ideas as opposed to keeping your feet on the ground. A relationship between two Intuitives is an amazing thing to observe – both partners are usually able to establish a connection that allows them to understand each other without words. The combination of intuition, introspection and imagination is likely to be a great driving force in your relationship.

Intuitives are relatively rare (only 15-25%), so the fact that you managed to find another Intuitive is impressive in itself. Usually, the connection between such partners is instantaneous, making them feel as if someone finally understands them. This is often a welcome break from all the comments about their tendency to have their heads in the clouds or to miss things that other personality types consider obvious. It is quite unlikely that two Intuitives will run out of things to talk about – this is a great advantage both in the dating phase and later on in the relationship.

Unfortunately, this is just one side of the coin. It is very important to be able to communicate with each other effectively, but it is often the practical matters that cause problems in Intuitive-Intuitive relationships. As both partners are going to favor abstract issues, ideas and future plans, one of them will inevitably have to take the lead and handle the concrete things, such as shopping, cooking, maintenance, and money management. Intuitives tend not to be good at these matters and this may cause tension in the relationship.

Another problem that you are likely to face is your tendency to distract each other. Intuitives often get lost in their world of ideas and possibilities, drifting from one concept to another – and while this is a wonderful trait when it comes to creativity and innovation, it can also cause significant problems in the relationship. It is important to take time to enjoy the present and the simple things in life – otherwise both partners may feel overwhelmed and tired all the time. Keep your eyes on the stars, but also remember to keep your feet on the ground.

Tips for both individuals:

1. **Deal with practical tasks.** Neither partner is likely to enjoy (or be good at) handling routine, daily tasks – however, it is important to deal with them on time, avoiding the buildup of problems.
2. **Do things that engage your creativity.** You both will find it easier to deal with ideas than practical things, so do not try to mimic the behavior of other people and push your partner (or yourself) to participate in activities that require good use of all five senses. This is especially important in the dating phase.
3. **Be realistic.** As Intuitives, you will both have plenty of ideas that may or may not be realistic. Do not overcommit yourselves.
4. **Enjoy the present.** You are both likely to spend a lot of time thinking about the future. Find a way to enjoy the present as well – time flows quickly.
5. **Share your ideas.** Imagination is one of your greatest assets – use it. Your partner will likely be able to see some things from a different perspective, while at the same time staying on the same wavelength as you.

An Observant (S) Partner

This is one of the most challenging, yet potentially most rewarding combinations. These traits determine how we see the world, how we think, how we communicate – and this is just scratching the surface. In some relationships, the schism between Intuitive and Observant traits is too great to bridge, and both partners may spend a lot of time thinking about what they are doing wrong, why their significant other seems to misunderstand them all the time and why they just do not listen. In other cases, both individuals are able to acknowledge their differences and turn them into strengths, thus neutralizing each other's weaknesses.

Actually, the main difference between Intuitive and Observant traits is quite easy to define. The Intuitive partner will focus on abstract things – ideas, introspection, possibilities, dreams, connections between events etc. Intuitives are *imaginaries* who spend more time thinking about the future than the present. The Observant partner, on the other hand, will prioritize concrete things – objects, senses, observation, facts, daily matters etc. Observant types are *doers* who focus on the present moment rather than the future.

Not surprisingly, this affects everything else, from observational abilities to communication styles. It is absolutely crucial that you both take time to understand how the other person thinks and processes things – all other traits fade in comparison. It is also worth noting that Observant personality types dominate society and this often leads to Intuitives' traits being dismissed as impractical or unrealistic – the Observant partner should avoid labeling their partner as “odd” or getting frustrated because “this is not what most people do”. Respect the differences.

If all goes well, however, you are likely to have a very rewarding relationship. The Intuitive partner will be able to inspire their significant other and come up with a myriad of interesting ideas, always keeping the relationship fresh and interesting. The Observant partner will be able to ensure that those ideas are grounded in reality, as well as handle practical matters that the Intuitive may forget. As always, communication is key in such relationships – there will be plenty of misunderstandings, especially at the very beginning, but they are unlikely to cause lasting damage if both partners are open-minded and willing to compromise.

Tips for you:

1. **Be patient.** Your Observant partner is likely to have difficulties understanding some of your ideas.
2. **Improve your observation skills.** Your imagination is a great asset, but it is not going to help when, for example, you have to remember your partner's favorite perfume or where you put the car keys.
3. **Keep your feet on the ground.** Intuitives often overestimate their abilities, enthusiastically embracing new and exciting ideas without thinking about the actual implementation.
4. **Remember to enjoy the present.** You are likely to spend way too much time thinking about the future. Find a way to enjoy the present as well – time flows quickly. Your Observant partner will certainly be able to help you with this.

Tips for your partner:

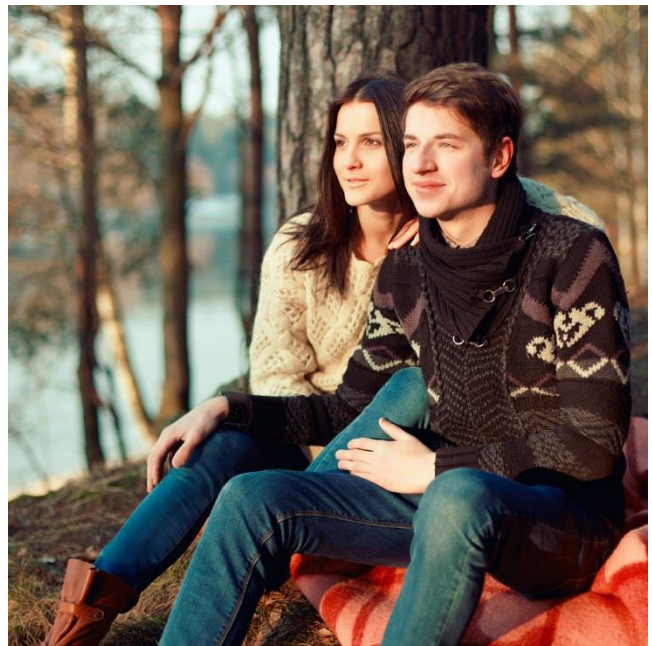
1. **Be patient.** Your Intuitive partner is likely to have difficulties handling practical tasks or noticing things.

2. **Improve your introspection skills.** You are likely to be practical and realistic, but it is also often necessary to spend some time reflecting on things. Forget the practical world and let yourself dream every once in a while.
3. **Be imaginative.** Observant types often focus too much on routines or physical things. Embrace your imagination and do not be afraid of exploring ideas without knowing whether they are actually practical or implementable.
4. **Remember to think about the future.** You are likely to focus either on the past or the present – find some time to think about the future as well, no matter how scary this may be. This does not mean that you should make complex long-term plans – simply imagine and explore possibilities in your mind. Your Intuitive partner is probably doing this all the time – you need to meet each other halfway.

A Thinking (T) Partner

A Thinker-Thinker relationship is usually free from dramas and emotional arguments – there will be disagreements, but they will be more reminiscent of calm, factual discussions than emotional storms. This does not necessarily mean that your disagreements will always be easier to overcome compared to the arguments between a Thinker and a Feeler, or between two Feelers – you will simply argue at a different level.

It is also important to point out that the dominance of the Thinking trait does not mean that the individual is unemotional. Both Thinkers and Feelers are capable of deep feelings – however, Thinkers tend to hide those feelings from the outside world. They want to stay in control, to not lose their heads regardless of the circumstances – and this is what creates that aura of indifference. Do not assume that your partner is completely calm and happy just because they are not showing their emotions.



This takes us to one of the main challenges in Thinker-Thinker relationships – expression of feelings. In all likelihood, you are both used to keeping your emotions inside, protecting your inner core from outside interference. This usually works very well in the professional environment, but romantic relationships come with a different set of requirements. There will be times when you will have to support your partner emotionally, express your feelings for him or her, or simply encourage them.

These things may not come naturally to you and it is very likely that you will feel quite vulnerable in such situations – however, it is important that both partners make conscious efforts to open up from time to time, showing what they truly feel.

Tips for both individuals:

1. **Do not be afraid to share your feelings.** You do not have to pretend that you are a highly rational robot in order for your partner to respect you. Expressing your feelings is perfectly OK.
2. **Be open-minded.** As Thinkers, you may find it difficult to tolerate a point of view that does not correspond to the facts you know. Accept the fact that your partner may have a different opinion.
3. **Be careful with criticism.** As Thinkers, you are likely to be quite resistant to criticism, but that does not mean that you should be dishing it out every time your partner makes a minor mistake. Just because there was little emotional reaction does not mean that your comments did not hurt.
4. **Know how to relax.** There is no need to contain yourself when you are having fun with your partner – learn to stop worrying about whether something makes sense.

A Feeling (F) Partner

A Thinker-Feeler relationship can be extremely rewarding as both individuals will be able teach each other how to look at things from an entirely different perspective. However, it is crucial that both you and your partner understand and respect your differences – there is nearly always some unjustified criticism coming from both sides. The Thinker complains that their partner is too emotional or irrational, and the Feeler responds by saying that the Thinker is cold and heartless. Such criticism becomes even more damaging when the Thinker is a woman and the Feeler is a man, with various social expectations coming into play as well.

The dominance of the Thinking trait does not mean that the individual is unemotional. Both Thinkers and Feelers are capable of deep feelings – however, Thinkers tend to hide those feelings from the outside world. They want to stay in control, to not lose their heads regardless of the circumstances – and this is what creates that aura of indifference.

Likewise, the dominance of the Feeling trait does not mean that the individual is irrational – they are simply using a different set of criteria, putting harmony and sensitivity above cold, hard facts. Feelers tend to show their feelings quite clearly, as opposed to containing them as Thinkers do – however, their decision process is still perfectly rational.

Both these perspectives are perfectly valid and this is one of the most important lessons you will have to learn in your relationship. If both partners are tolerant and open-minded, a Thinker-Feeler relationship can be very inspiring and successful, with the Thinker making fact-based decisions and the Feeler bringing warmth and harmony into the relationship.

Tips for you:

1. **Be tolerant.** Remember that your partner may not value the facts as much as you do – they are likely to prioritize harmony, values and morals.
2. **Observe.** Your partner is likely to be good at gauging other people's emotional state and they may expect the same from you – try to learn how to read the cues. Yes, it can be frustrating to hear “I am fine” when something is obviously wrong, but bear in mind that this is simply a mismatch of expectations. You are used to dealing with data, they are used to dealing with emotions.
3. **Be careful with criticism.** Feelers tend to be very vulnerable to criticism – be careful when you are pointing something out and try to do this in a calm, non-confrontational manner.
4. **Know how to relax.** There is no need to contain yourself when you are having fun with your partner – learn to stop worrying about whether something makes sense.

Tips for your partner:

1. **Be tolerant.** Remember that your partner may be more interested in facts than in what other people feel – they are likely to focus on finding a rational solution.
2. **Stay calm.** Try not to take criticism personally – in some cases, your partner will simply be criticizing an idea or assessing a situation as opposed to pointing out your flaws.
3. **Observe.** Do not assume that your partner is completely calm and happy just because they are not showing their emotions.
4. **Be patient.** In all likelihood, your partner will not be as good as you are at gauging other people's emotional state – consequently, there will be times when they will completely misunderstand your emotions or get frustrated by not being able to deduce what you want to say. Thinkers are used to dealing with data, not emotions.

A Judging (J) Partner

Judgers enjoy planning and committing to things as opposed to keeping their options open. As you both share this trait, it is unlikely that you will have difficulties making up your minds and sticking to specific goals or plans. This will contribute greatly to the stability of your relationship, with both partners always staying on track and focusing on what has to be done.

As Judgers, you are also likely to be dedicated and patient partners, putting your duties above pleasure. You will both work hard on the relationship and have no difficulties making up your minds, especially when it comes to future plans.

On the other hand, there are two sides to every story and Judger-Judger relationships are not an exception. Planning and scheduling inevitably come with a degree of inflexibility and this can cause tension in the relationship. There may be times when you will commit to things that are in conflict, without checking with each other first. Not surprisingly, two Judgers may often clash with each other, with their need for closure demanding a clear solution and a clear path forward.

There is another problem that you may face. You are both likely to find it difficult to change your habits or long-held views – this is a good trait when it comes to duties and commitments, but it can also prevent you from keeping your eyes open for better alternatives. For instance, Judgers are likely to defend their opinions quite fiercely, unwilling to give up and accept a different point of view. Consequently, you may

never know what opportunities you have missed. This covers many things, ranging from hobbies to holiday plans – shaking things up can bring a lot of variety and novelty into the relationship. Do not be afraid to experiment or simply be more spontaneous every once in a while.

Unlike Prospectors (P), who are generally more relaxed about their duties and deadlines, Judgers are also likely to get stressed when things do not go according to their plans. Watch out for these tendencies and learn to step away from that strict work ethic in your relationship when a situation demands. This does not mean that you have to stop making plans or start living completely in the present – rather, there needs to be a balance between stability and spontaneity, and you will both have to decide where that balance is in your relationship.

Tips for both individuals:

1. **Be open-minded.** As Judgers, you may find it challenging to accept the fact that there may be more than one right answer to a problem. Try not to be stubborn and argumentative in cases where you both have different opinions.
2. **Experiment.** Your tendency to plan and prepare may make things difficult when there is a need to experiment or try something new. Learn to let go and act spontaneously from time to time.
3. **Do not exhaust yourselves.** Your desire to get things done can bring a lot of stress into your own lives and into the relationship. Learn to step back and relax – the world is not going to collapse if you miss a self-imposed deadline.
4. **Find time for each other.** Do not get so caught up in plans, tasks and order that you lose sight of what is really important. There is nothing wrong with being playful and simply having fun instead of doing yet another task. All work and no play is not the way to go in a relationship.

A Prospecting (P) Partner

In contrast to Judgers, Prospectors like to keep their options open, always looking for alternatives and opportunities. A relationship between a Judger and a Prospector may often be rocky and challenging, but there is a lot of potential as well if both partners are willing to take time to explore and understand each other's differences.

The main difficulty is going to be the fact that you will likely hold diametrically opposite views when it comes to planning and execution of those plans. The Judger will try to come up with an agenda and then stick to it until the end. The Prospector will refuse to lay out all the possibilities and probabilities, making things up as they go along – and then maybe even abandoning the project once the most interesting task has been completed. Not surprisingly, both partners can easily frustrate each other if these traits are not addressed or understood.

However, there are two sides to every story and Judger-Prospector relationships are not an exception. Judgers' planning and scheduling inevitably come with a degree of inflexibility and this can bring tension into the relationship – which can then be defused by the easygoing Prospector. Likewise, Prospectors can be indecisive or even somewhat lazy, only focusing on the fun tasks and ignoring the rest – this can be counterbalanced by the driven and dutiful Judger. As long as both partners refrain from name-calling and are willing to compromise, these differences can be turned into major strengths, covering each partner's respective weaknesses.

In order to achieve this, you will have to make conscious efforts to meet each other halfway. The Judging partner should not be afraid to experiment or simply be more spontaneous every once in a while, even if that means changing their habits or long-held views. Similarly, the perceiving partner should resist the urge to always seek something new and exciting, even when it is very difficult to stick to the plan or manage all the chores. In all likelihood, each partner will be willing to help their significant other with things that they find challenging, but it is unreasonable to expect them to do this every single time. There needs to be a balance between Judger's stability and Prospector's spontaneity, and you will both have to decide where that balance is in your relationship.

Tips for you:

1. **Communicate.** Your partner's indecisiveness or relaxed attitude will often frustrate you. Do not resort to name-calling and try to understand what drives them and how you can both support each other. Remember that your partner may not be as interested in plans and schedules as you are – they are used to keeping their options open.

2. **Be open-minded.** As a Judger, you may find it challenging to accept the fact that there may be more than one right answer to a problem. Try not to be stubborn and argumentative in cases where your partner disagrees with you.
3. **Experiment.** Your tendency to plan and prepare may make things difficult when there is a need to experiment or try something new. Learn to let go and act spontaneously from time to time.
4. **Do not exhaust yourself.** Your desire to get things done can bring a lot of stress into your own life and into the relationship. Learn to step back and relax – the world is not going to collapse if you miss a self-imposed deadline.

Tips for your partner:

1. **Communicate.** Your partner's inflexibility or desire to have everything planned out will often frustrate you. Do not resort to name-calling and try to understand what drives them and how you can both support each other. Remember that your partner is used to putting their plans and schedules above play and rest – they may find it quite difficult to step back and relax.
2. **Focus.** As a Prospector, you probably enjoy trying out new things and often wonder whether the grass is greener on the other side. Learn to stick to your tasks and do not let your mind drift away when there is a job to be done.
3. **Watch your environment.** You will likely have a much higher tolerance for disorder compared to your Judging partner. Do not ignore your housekeeping duties.
4. **Do not be picky.** Prospectors tend to balk at doing routine, menial tasks, often wandering off in search of something more exciting. Not all work is fun, but you should make conscious efforts to do your fair share of household duties.

Assertive or Turbulent?

The format of this subsection will differ from that of the others, simply because we see the final trait as a variant of the personality rather than an integral part of the actual personality type. However, the importance of this trait should not be understated – it determines how confident we are in our abilities and decisions, which certainly affects our behavior in romantic relationships.

Assertive individuals tend to be emotionally stable, calm and relaxed – they do not easily get upset or excited, keeping their emotions in the proverbial middle of the scale. Their calm temper allows them to sort out any disagreements without much stress as opposed to being rattled even by the most insignificant of issues. Furthermore, individuals with this personality trait tend to be quite optimistic and content about their achievements and life in general. That said, this relaxed attitude can also encourage Assertive individuals to not worry too much about goals or self-improvement in their relationships, with their self-confidence overshadowing any signs that might make someone else question whether more work needs to be done.

In contrast, Turbulent individuals tend to be much more self-conscious and more reactive to stress. They are prone to experiencing “emotional roller coasters”, e.g. feeling at the top of the world in the morning and being overrun by negative thoughts in the evening. Turbulent types also tend to be more success-driven and perfectionistic than Assertive ones, often worrying way too much about their performance, image or future. On the other hand, this desire to do their best and never-ending quest for improvement often help these individuals achieve impressive heights in their career or pleasantly surprise their other half, simply because they really care about whether they are being good enough.

At first sight, it may seem that the Assertive trait is preferable – after all, what is not to like about being self-confident and relaxed? However, somewhat ironically, being resistant to stress and pressure may not always be a good thing. Despite being more prone to emotional swings and worrying, Turbulent individuals are also likely to be more reflective and organized, often pushing themselves harder than necessary. However, it is exactly that “must do better” attitude that makes them put in more effort into the relationship. Depending on other traits, Assertive individuals may also be more likely to take risks – where a Turbulent person may hesitate and weigh their options, an Assertive one may trust themselves just a little too much and make a mistake.

Ultimately, though, everything boils down to each partner’s willingness to recognize and address both the individual weaknesses inherent in each trait, and the potential ways their respective traits may complement or clash with each other. It is also important to remember that many things depend on how strongly expressed the trait is – the higher the score, the starker the characteristics are likely to be.

Let's now briefly discuss three potential combinations.

If both partners are Assertive

This is probably the most straightforward combination. You are likely to be confident, relaxed optimists, quite happy with your relationship and where it is going. If you are both Extraverted and Assertive, you are also likely to be more satisfied with life in general. You may rarely experience strong positive emotions, but you will not have many negative ones either. You will also probably feel quite relaxed about your work or your social status, instead trusting yourself and paying more attention to what you want, not what others say you should do.

On the other hand, you need to beware of the tendency to assume that everything is OK and not be perturbed by occasional issues in your relationship – by doing this, you can miss crucial signs that something is going in the wrong direction or that you may potentially face bigger issues further down the road. Too much confidence can be just as bad as too little confidence. Even if everything seems great and there is nothing that can upset you, finding some time for reflection and thinking about improvement can be a very healthy exercise.

If one partner is Assertive and another is Turbulent

As with all other traits, if partners are on opposite sides of the scale, there is a lot of potential for both mutual personal growth and various misunderstandings. With the Assertive partner being the decisive, calm and level-headed half, and the Turbulent partner being the cautious, sensitive and self-conscious one, it is easy to see that they can both help and hurt each other.

In such relationships, it is important to understand each other's strengths and weaknesses instead of assuming that there is something wrong with another person's attitude.

The Assertive individual should recognize that their Turbulent partner is much more emotionally reactive and vulnerable to stressful situations. They may be more pessimistic, anxious and shy – however, the Turbulent trait also pushes such individuals to reflect on their decisions and try to improve themselves and their relationships as much as possible. As a side effect, Turbulent individuals are also likely to be more organized, driven and motivated. If they are able to master their emotions and use them

as a driving force instead of simply giving in to the mood swings, this trait can actually be quite beneficial in a romantic relationship.

Similarly, the Turbulent individual should understand that their partner's calmness and relaxed attitude do not mean that they are unsupportive or not that interested in working on the relationship. Being less likely to feel nervous in challenging situations, Assertive individuals may seem somewhat detached or disinterested, especially from the perspective of someone who is Turbulent – however, it is precisely that emotional stability that should be utilized where possible. While it is true that Assertive individuals may sometimes be too self-confident and not care much about achieving the best possible results where a good outcome is enough, this level-headedness can also be invaluable in emotionally charged or unpredictable situations.

With this in mind, both partners should work on covering each other's weaknesses with their respective strengths instead of focusing on their differences and trying to "fix" them. For instance, the Assertive individual could act as an emotional bedrock for their much more sensitive partner, showing that there is always a bright side, reassuring their other half that the matter at hand may not be worth stressing about, and encouraging them to put their perfectionism aside and take a bolder, riskier step every now and then. Similarly, the Turbulent individual could bring more organization and goals into the couple's life, with their hard work and success-driven attitude pushing both partners to grow and develop instead of being content with where they are. The presence of the Turbulent trait may also act as a safeguard against decisions whose potential consequences may be underestimated by the Assertive partner, who may not care too much about choosing the best possible option or worry about how their actions may be perceived by others.

If both partners are Turbulent

This combination is likely to be the most tempestuous of all, with both partners leaning towards the emotional and anxious side of the scale. While the couple will probably experience very strong positive emotions, they will be accompanied by negative feelings – and it is in those moments that both partners have to remember to take a couple of deep breaths and refocus their thoughts and emotions. Otherwise there is a risk that they will end up fuelling each other's anxiety, with minor frustrations boiling over

and becoming a full-blown crisis. Turbulent individuals are vulnerable to stress and they may need to make a conscious effort to find mutually acceptable ways to fight it and relax instead of stressing each other out even further.

That said, the Turbulent trait can also work in the couple's favor, if both partners are able to recognize and address its accompanying weaknesses. Being reflective and self-conscious, they will likely find time to think about both the present and the future, readjusting the course as they go instead of blindly trusting themselves. While this may lead to plenty of soul-searching conversations around the dinner table, focusing on all the stressors in their life, the perfectionism and sensitivity shared by Turbulent partners will also encourage them to address those issues and try to find good solutions instead of writing them off as irrelevant and going on with their lives. Nearly any weakness can be turned into a strength, and this is one of such examples.

Friendships

It is not easy to become an INTJ's friend. People with this personality type value rationality and intelligence more than anything else, and tend to automatically assume that most of the individuals they meet are likely to be less intelligent than they are. Most would probably call it arrogance; INTJs would rationalize this as a natural filtering mechanism and argue that most people simply bore them. Consequently, INTJs tend to have very few good friends, but they also do not really see the need to have a big social circle.



INTJ personalities are very independent and self-sufficient. They see their friends more as intellectual soul mates than as sources of social validation and assurance. INTJs will happily come up with new ways to improve and deepen the relationship, but they will not be dependent on their friends emotionally. Furthermore, it is quite unlikely that the INTJ will enjoy physical manifestations of feelings (hugs, touches, etc.), even with close friends.

INTJ friends will also find that people with this personality type are very difficult to “read”. Not only are INTJs comparatively unemotional, they are also likely to try to suppress emotions that get through their mental filters. Emotions are definitely the INTJ's Achilles' heel, so they do their best to not let them through, for fear of breaching that shield of logic and rationality. And vice versa, INTJs may be quite insensitive when it comes to their friends' feelings. In all likelihood, the INTJ would honestly have no clue how to react to something on the emotional level.

That being said, INTJs have no difficulties relaxing and enjoying themselves among close friends. Their renowned sarcasm and dark humor make INTJ personalities great storytellers, as long as the audience can understand (and withstand) their jokes. This is one of the reasons why INTJs are usually very fond of Analysts or Diplomats; they can read between the lines and follow the INTJ's train of thought. In contrast, Observant types are likely to find this personality type quite frustrating.

People with the INTJ personality type tend to be truly gifted and bright individuals, seeking personal growth and development, and encouraging their friends to follow the same path. If the INTJ is able to connect with another person at this level, their friendship will likely be strong and long-lasting. INTJs are generally very “low maintenance” friends, who do not require much attention or constant contact. They understand the value of privacy and independence, and will actually push their friends to become more independent as well.

Parenthood

INTJ personality traits are not usually considered ideal as far as parenting is concerned. INTJs tend to be very rational, perfectionistic and relatively insensitive individuals, which goes against the stereotypical image of warm, caring, traditional parents. However, it could be said that this is simply a reflection of the fact that society is dominated by more sensitive and traditional personality types. In



contrast, INTJ parents are more likely to focus on making sure that their children grow up to be able to make independent and rational decisions.

INTJs are very growth-oriented individuals and this attitude is usually reflected in their parenting style. An INTJ parent will not worry too much about putting rules and structures in place, or be overprotective. Rather, they will give their children plenty of freedom and encourage them to explore and experience, learn and grow, question and challenge – as desire for autonomy lies deep within every INTJ, they will do their best to teach their children to value that as well.

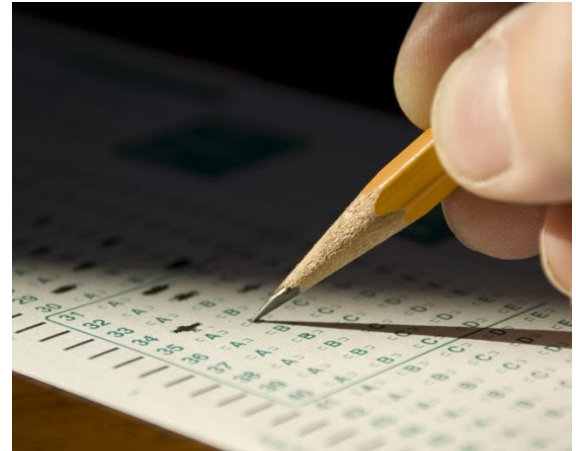
This certainly does not mean that INTJs are careless parents – on the contrary, they will spend a lot of time and effort in preparation for the arrival of the child, likely stocking up on parenting books and articles. However, INTJ parents will always put their child's personal growth above their desire for security and stability, provided that there are no risks in doing so. Likewise, an INTJ will rarely have difficulties disciplining their child if that becomes necessary.

People with the INTJ personality type will also likely have difficulties supporting their children emotionally. They will be excellent advisors when it comes to planning, rational advice, help with studies, etc., but INTJ parents are unlikely to know how to react when their child asks for their help with a matter that is emotional in nature. INTJs are used to suppressing their own emotions and will struggle if their child is very sensitive. There are many other personality types that have difficulties in this area, but INTJ personalities are likely to find this especially challenging.

That being said, most INTJ parents will be able to ensure that their children are very well prepared to deal with the challenges that life throws their way. They will likely be demanding yet liberal and open-minded parents, encouraging their children to develop and use their own mind instead of trying to protect them from the world for as long as possible. This open-mindedness is one of the best traits of INTJ parents – they will not try to force their children to live up to their expectations or comply with various norms and traditions, like many other personality types do. The INTJ will simply want their child to be able to set their own goals and have enough willpower to achieve them – everything else will be secondary.

Academic Path

Some people spend nearly one third of their lives studying. Some choose to enter the workforce earlier and don't spend as much time in classes or libraries. Regardless, most people spend at least some of their important formative years in school. No matter how long you remain in the academic world, your time there is important. These years not only could set one on a specific career path, but the school experience can also affect self-esteem and other aspects of psychology well into the future – in both positive and negative ways.



INTJs are one of the rarest personality types and, because of this, those around them don't always understand their sometimes bookish and standoffish ways. This can create difficulty in school. Knowing the challenges an INTJ faces in the academic world can go a long way in helping them make the best use of their time and experience. To help INTJs get positive results from any academic path they follow, let's explore some guidelines based on their traits.

How INTJs Learn

INTJs are intuitive thinkers. Some have described their style as absorbing details like a sponge, almost subconsciously, and then allowing their powerful intuition to combine the details into rich tapestry of custom ideas. This subconscious process doesn't involve much deliberate thought or design. It just "happens" without steps or techniques.

A loose analogy for the way INTJs learn is Georges Seurat's technique as an artist. This 19th Century French painter was the one most associated with an art technique called pointillism. Pointillist painters used dots of paint rather than sweeping brush strokes to create their masterpieces. The mind then assembles the thousands of dots to form a picture filled with human activity, landscape and emotion. Without much thought and in a microsecond, the dabs of paint merge and beautifully represent a day in a French park. Focusing just on the tiny dots, the painting has no story. Without the dots, there would be

no painting. This is similar to how INTJs approach the world. This is important to understanding the INTJs' strengths in the classroom.

A mechanistic view of what happens is this: After INTJs gather the facts, they process them with their strong intuition where they discover connections and meaning from the material. From there they filter their insights back through their thinking. There they organize and polish the revelations. In their thinking, the INTJs will review the results to make sure that evidence and logic support their conclusions. If it does, INTJs will accept it as “something learned” and the conclusion will be something they feel comfortable presenting. Obviously, it's a much more organic process than words will allow and can happen in seconds, but that is essentially how it works. A popular culture example of this style of thinking might be Sherlock Holmes from the modern BBC series.

For INTJs to do this and to learn according to their unique style, the teacher, the topic and the classroom methods need to free them to run around in their mental playgrounds. Trying to pin them down and restrict the way they organize their thoughts is counterproductive. Their imaginations and creativity need room to explore. If the curriculum is too tight and too focused, INTJs will not only be uncomfortable. They may “check out” and go through the motions just to get through it as quickly as possible. This can work on a practical level, but may be wasted time for the student.

INTJs love a puzzle that needs solving. Whether the problem is theoretical or has an immediate practical application doesn't matter. Many have said that Analysts see the world as a big chessboard, and their only goal is to become chess masters. They like to plan and prefer a clear idea of where they are going with a lesson. Like most Intuitive and Judging types, INTJs are more comfortable with plenty of time to deliberate before an instructor asks for an answer to a complex problem. Not because they are slow, but because they are thorough. Imagine INTJs as hunched over a chess board taking their time as they sort out their next move and anticipating future moves.

INTJs in High School

In the classroom: INTJ is the personality type that most aligns with high achievement. High IQs are also common in this group. INTJs, especially Turbulent ones, are perfectionists and will do whatever it takes to embrace high standards – which are usually of their own creation rather than from external demands.

They will dedicate a great amount of time and effort to solve a complex problem or unravel a mystery. The creator of the Rubik's Cube must have made it for this personality type. As far as earning good grades, this comes naturally to INTJs – although they may falter if the goals and purpose of a curriculum seem too vague or trivial. But even when they falter, with their intelligence and their work ethic, they will, nonetheless, pull through and receive good grades even in those subjects. Their curiosity will put them well above the ordinary student when it comes to the energy they apply to studying.

Developmentally speaking, conceptualization, seeing beyond the concrete, will still be novel tools for INTJs entering high school. Like a new toy, abstract thoughts will feel invigorating to young INTJs as they begin to enjoy a fuller experience within their intuitive selves. Combine this with the growth of their knowledge and intelligence, and they blossom into formidable students.

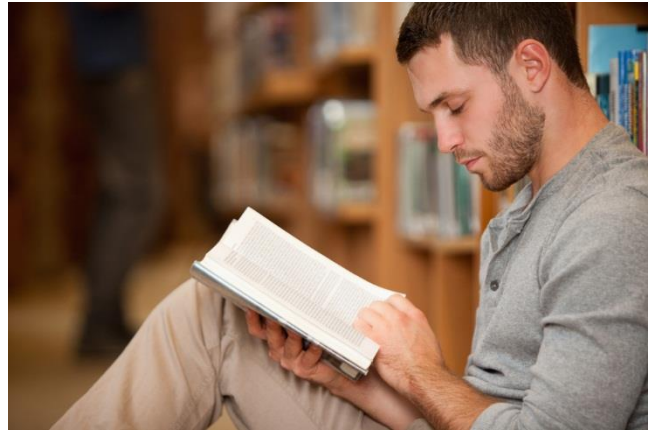
When they choose their courses, science, technology and the arts will attract INTJs. These allow them to shine as “the seekers of solutions” and provide them with the skills they need to enjoy a sense of “wizardry” or expertise. Political science and economics may prove interesting to them for similar reasons. However, grades alone will not tell their story. They will do well in any courses they take, but the subjects may not leave INTJs with a sense of fulfillment.

However, even with all of their academic strengths, the INTJ's high school years are not without certain challenges. All kinds of social problems that creep into the classroom may bother INTJs and disrupt their learning. INTJs' reclusive behavior combined with their academic skill might cause their peers to label them as “nerds” and “geeks”. This may result in bullying which can be a distraction in the classroom. While other people's regard for them doesn't generally concern INTJs when it's a passive thing, the active nature of abuse that comes with bullying can be troublesome for them. INTJs may need to take care not to exacerbate the problem by showing impatience with their classmates who will generally take longer to learn what the INTJs will see as elementary.

INTJs may not apply much work to certain subjects when they see how easily things come to them. They may take it for granted that they will do well and not put as much effort into acing tests and papers especially if the subject doesn't excite them. They are typically not as bound by conventional rules and structure in their inner lives and attitude as others. INTJs will not necessarily see this neglect as “being

lazy” or not attending to their work. The bigger picture always takes priority and the need for a clear, structured goal will always be more important. This may not be wise on their part as even the smaller details have value. Learning to be disciplined regardless of how one feels can be a needed life lesson. Nonetheless, not applying themselves fully to all their work will not cause INTJs in high school to lose sleep at night. They will probably do just as well anyway whether they put in the time and attention or not.

Outside the classroom: If you’ve been to high school, you don’t have to watch a single one of the thousands of films about teenage angst to know that there’s more to high school than just classes. And most would agree that there are as many lessons in a school’s yards and hallways as there are in the classroom. So, let’s take a moment to consider high school as a place where some important social lessons unfold.



INTJs are rare, and their uniqueness may not be appreciated in high school where “not being an oddball” is a social priority. As mentioned above, bullying in school can be a problem for INTJs who are different, reclusive, and smart. Combine this with their lack of interest in being popular or playing what they would regard as the “games” needed for climbing the social ladder in high school and you have the makings of an “outsider”. Being an outsider in high school can be difficult even if one creates that role for himself. More than likely, you’ll find INTJs hanging out alone or with a small group of people who are similar to themselves. This, in itself, can feed unpleasant and unfair stereotypes.

INTJs will feel more comfortable in academic, science or technical extracurricular groups. It may take some encouragement to get them to join any organization at all. However, it will take less encouragement if the topic is right. They might join a club that involves robotics or rocketry. Any group that highlights skills and intelligence will draw INTJs. Chess club, art club, Latin Club, the Debate Team, the Model UN... anything that challenges them and presents an interesting mental exercise would be something they might join.

INTJs occasionally take a leadership role in extracurricular groups, but usually only when their “expertise” and problem-solving skills are required. INTJs often take on an observer’s role, only becoming involved when it is obvious the group needs their skills to move forward effectively. They will wait until they see that those in charge are in over their heads. While they aren’t comfortable in the limelight, their need to solve problems may supersede their hesitation to step forward and take charge.

Work or College?

While there are many other reasons for deciding whether to go college than personality types, they can have a role in the equation. Not long ago, most thought of college or university as the quickest path to success and security. Now some of the same people are vigorously arguing against higher education for everyone having seen college dropouts succeed on a grand scale in our technological age. Steve Jobs and Bill Gates are the two most famous examples. College is just one possible path to discovering one’s niche. So, what might the INTJ consider when thinking about college?

Two questions that INTJs should ask when deciding whether to hit the books or enter the workforce:

- *Will a degree be necessary in the work you want to aim for?* Considering their interests, INTJs may want to earn credentials whether in the form of a license or a degree. Being a scientist, economist, political scientist, lawyer, professor or academic researcher obviously needs some training. The careers they choose often need a diploma.
- *Will you be able to gain something intangible and yet valuable from going to college?* For many there is more to a higher education than just getting a job. It’s a life passage and opportunity to grow and take steps toward becoming an independent young adult. There is wide opportunity at college to explore the systems, theories and models that INTJs are so fond of. The guidance and the dedicated time available at college can be helpful for young Analysts who are discovering their places in the world.

When INTJs go to College

INTJs who choose to go to a college or university will feel at home almost immediately – maybe not socially, but academically. No matter what high school experience they had, INTJs have a real

opportunity to shine when they go to college. And unlike most high schools, the right colleges can give INTJs a larger opportunity to free and exercise their powerful and creative intellects.

College is a time for INTJs to begin to consider and exploit their strengths and talents in a real way. They may find kindred spirits who they can play off in the classroom and in study groups. They may even become dismayed when they find similar personality types in the room at the same time. Other Analysts may come to the same place for the same reason, unlike high school. Suddenly, the INTJ may not be the only Analyst in the pond, nor the smartest kid in class. This could create some resentment and a competitive environment that could be new territory that may take some adjustment.

Subjects that might attract INTJs in college include: science (any kind), technology (any kind), economics, political science, law, business analysis, education, and anthropology just to name a handful. INTJs will do well with anything they try. However, a major that demands they arrange complex and tangled facts into something that makes sense will appeal most to them. The question for INTJ is not whether they can do well with any subject they find themselves studying. They have the fundamental intelligence and dedication to do well in any class. The question is: Will they feel fulfilled.

Some feel that college and university is only about getting the tools you need to make a good living. INTJs may adopt that as the goal they are trying to reach. From the list of the preferred majors above, it's easy to see the courses which can comfortably lead to well-paying jobs. However, that is more because INTJs have unique talents that are rare enough and valuable enough to warrant a large income rather. The major they choose may or may not be an effort to create financial security. Their underlying purpose in college will be to become better problem-solvers in whatever field for which they aim.

One area of difficulty for INTJs in colleges is the need to go to those courses none of us want to – the foundational, prerequisite courses. Most INTJs will “test out” of these, making them unnecessary. And they will probably make their lives easier by doing so if they have the opportunity. However, into every college career a little mundane must fall. Some needed courses will be too elementary for INTJs and lack the challenge they need. They may find them dull – or worse - irrelevant. However, learning to cope with this may also be a good disciplinary practice for INTJs and other Analysts. It won't be the last time they run into necessary tasks that feel meaningless and boring. While they would rather spend their time in

their intellectual ivory towers, in the real productive world, the mundane constantly invades our lives. College can help the aware INTJ gain a degree of tolerance for such detail and prepare them to approach the adult world in a more practical manner.

Like most young people, the INTJ will delight in the social autonomy that going away to college offers. For most students, this is the first significant taste of life apart from their families and their families' rules. Some even choose their universities based on its distance from the family home. It's no different for the INTJs who are as interested in coming into their own. If they had a hard time at school or at home because of their personality traits, it may be a relief to escape that. However, the "party life" will probably hold little attraction for INTJs. They put too little priority on their social lives and would prefer to be on their own or with a small group of friends. They will most likely continue their same slightly awkward or uninterested social style into college and on a more adult level.

However, they may take an excursion into the party life if stress from their hard work and their perfectionism becomes overwhelming. INTJs, especially Turbulent ones, tend to be perfectionists and that causes them to be hard on themselves. If they start creating too much pressure in their lives, they may react by going in the opposite direction of their normally hardworking selves. Parties, alcohol, drugs and casual sex are not out of the question with such a reaction. However, a party will be a strange and untamed place for INTJs and their need for control and activities with clear goals will eventually take over. More likely than not, such adventures will be no more than short-lived phases for the INTJ.

For the typical INTJ, university life may feel like the first step away from the "amateur league" and a step closer to a professional player in whatever field they follow. As they advance with their coursework through their undergraduate work and then in their pursuit of graduate degrees, they will feel more and more like they coming into their own. And while INTJs may never be social gadflies, those around them will likely begin to gain a respect for their abilities and, by extension, the INTJ.

Career and Professional Development

INTJ personalities are known for their ability to digest difficult and complex theories and principles relevant to their careers, and then convert them into clear and actionable ideas. INTJs are excellent strategists, possessing intuition and confidence that allow them to devise and implement challenging long-term plans without many problems. These skills can be tremendously valuable in the right career path. People with this personality type are great at jobs that involve planning, strategy, and application of complex theoretical principles. For instance, you could find many INTJs among project managers, system engineers, or marketing strategists. These are often their best career choices.



Typical INTJ careers also tend to put a lot of importance on independent thinking. INTJs love difficult challenges and strongly detest routine, doing whatever they can to avoid or automate mind-numbing tasks. It is difficult to imagine an INTJ willingly choosing a strictly administrative or teamwork-focused role. INTJs excel as “lone wolves”, which makes them excellent scientists and researchers; INTJs need to have enough breathing space to use their creativity and dedication without being constantly questioned by other team members.

People with this personality type put effectiveness and competence above everything else. Consequently, the best INTJ careers reward personal initiative and determination. INTJs believe that everyone should do their best to complete their task to the highest possible standard and loathe individuals who use social activities and networking rather than merit to get ahead on the career ladder. There is no easier way to lose the respect of an INTJ than to show that you believe social skills and relationships are more important than professional competence. INTJs have very high standards, especially when it comes to their own work, and are likely to put in an extraordinary amount of effort to get the job done. Consequently, typical INTJ careers reward inventiveness, dedication and insightfulness.

INTJs tend to have excellent analytical and creative skills. They are highly unlikely to choose or enjoy customer-facing or teamwork-oriented careers; these are definitely not the best choices for INTJs. As already mentioned, INTJs are brilliant strategists and planners, but they do best alone or in small teams. People with this personality type will gladly accept someone else's authority and leadership, as long as they see that individual as competent. These traits make INTJs excellent engineers, military strategists, programmers, system analysts, lawyers, or freelance consultants. These are typical INTJ career paths and their performance in these areas is often very impressive.

INTJs thrive in fields where they can combine their imagination, open-mindedness and strategic thinking skills. They are usually fascinated by research, pattern-seeking, hypotheses, possibilities and options. More often than not, INTJs also have many grand dreams and ambitions – however, they are likely to keep them hidden, even from their inner circle.

Regardless of the area they are working in, INTJs are problem solvers at heart. Nothing fascinates them more than finding an error in a system and coming up with an effective, innovative solution. People with this personality type are strategic thinkers, able to jump from step A to step D and then come back to steps B and C without much effort. INTJs are often called masterminds for a reason – their quiet determination and reasoning skills give them a distinct advantage over other personality types when it comes to a strategic approach to career planning.

Unfortunately, despite being versatile and highly intelligent, INTJs are likely to face many difficulties in their careers if they choose the wrong path. People with this personality type are rare and their quiet nature does not help either – consequently, they usually have difficulties finding inspiring role models or getting good advice when it comes to career planning. Jobs that are perfectly suitable for 80%+ of the population would likely frustrate and exhaust most INTJs very quickly.

So, how do you choose the right path?

Getting on the Career Ladder

The best thing about being an INTJ is that people with this personality type tend to be extremely versatile. Jacks-of-all-trades, geeks, nitpickers, walking encyclopedias – INTJs will have heard these compliments

many times throughout their lives. Actually, most other personality types would not even see these sayings as compliments to begin with. Like other Analysts, INTJs are unstoppable when they get a chance to combine their knowledge with their imagination – but getting such an opportunity can be a challenge.

Whatever their hobbies or aspirations, INTJs do best when they embrace technology and science. It does not really matter whether a particular INTJ wants or is able to get into a purely technological field – sometimes their chosen profession has no direct links with technology. What matters is the INTJ's ability to exploit and utilize the available technological and scientific tools in a way that not only excites their imagination, but also increases the efficiency of the entire system.

INTJs should embrace these strengths in the job-hunting stage as well. The bad news is that they are unlikely to do well when it comes to networking and socializing – the primary means of getting a job for many other personality types. INTJs can become better at this as time goes by, e.g. by only targeting like-minded individuals and taking time to improve their social skills – however, this is not by any means mandatory and many people with this personality type will do just fine without an extensive social network.

The good news is that Analysts know how to plan and INTJs are particularly good in this area. And this is what they should focus on – thinking about what they want to achieve in life and then working backwards, developing several possible action plans. Finding out what the first steps could be, mapping out the potential channels, crafting the introductory e-mail and presenting the arguments – these things come naturally to INTJs and they should not hesitate to focus on such strengths. Not many people have the willpower or imagination necessary to come up with a highly targeted approach – however, one good e-mail sent to the right person is often much better than 100+ random applications.

Of course, you need to be able to present your skills in the right way in order to distinguish yourself among other candidates. As an INTJ, you probably find many things interesting, maybe even seeing them as hobbies. Utilize this – think about what hobbies could be attractive in a specific field and then find a way to turn those ideas into real-life projects. There are plenty of opportunities out there – you can participate in competitions or volunteer projects, build an online presence (e.g. a small blog), or write a couple of articles and try to get them published in the print media. It does not really matter what you do,

as long as it is something you can put on your resume. Not only will this make you a more attractive and versatile candidate, but will also give you a lot of breathing space in the interview. Answering a question like “describe a situation where you used your problem-solving skills” is much, much easier when you have 5+ projects listed on your CV. Be imaginative – your skills are not worth much if you are the only person who knows about them.

You may also need to brush up on your presentation skills. If you have an interview coming up, great – but do not make the mistake of thinking that your technical knowledge and enthusiasm will put you above everybody else. No matter how cliché that sounds, you need to be aware of the most common interview techniques and questions so that you are not caught off-guard by something like “what is your biggest weakness?” – answering “perfectionism” or “I work too hard” is not going to result in bonus points, quite the contrary. Try to highlight your achievements and knowledge, but also be prepared to get many template questions, especially in early stages. In some cases, the recruiter will not know much about the role and will simply be going through a checklist – expect that and do not let your confidence cloud your judgment when it comes to preparation. INTJs tend to be very good candidates, but they usually find it difficult to get that message across and may consequently lose out to less qualified but better prepared candidates.

Thanks to their strategic thinking and planning skills, INTJs rarely have major difficulties when it comes to landing their first job. However, it is also important to always keep everything in perspective. People with this personality type often say that they studied extremely hard in school, with their eyes fixed on getting a position in a specific field – but then regretted missing the chance during their school years to develop personal relationships that could have helped them a lot later on. INTJs are very independent and strong-willed individuals, but their perfectionistic tendencies may lead to a lot of stress – and having a social support network, no matter how small, would be of great help in such situations.

You should also never forget to listen to yourself, especially when deciding what would be a good career choice. INTJs are good at self-reflection, but this trait is often clouded by other factors, such as outside influences and financial rewards. In the end, you are the only one who knows what is going to make you truly happy. This does not mean that you should have unrealistic expectations at the start of your career – entry-level jobs are rarely interesting or satisfying – but it is your responsibility to find the right career

path. Do not choose a profession just because it pays well or is seen as prestigious. Other personality types may get away with it, but as an INTJ, you will always know that you are in the wrong place and that feeling will not be quelled by materialistic or social arguments.

Professional Development

Let us take a look at what makes INTJs good at what they are doing, and then move on to discussing what traits are behind most of their problems.

INTJs often say that the best thing about their job, whatever it may be, is using creativity and decisiveness to find and solve problems related to various systemic issues. In other words, people with this personality type tend to be less interested in why entry #319 in the accounting journal contains incorrect information; they ask why the system is not good enough to pick this up automatically. INTJs are the ultimate masterminds, and this is not some kind of feel-good overstatement. Some personality types are great at being empathic, which wins them many friends in the workplace. Others excel at living in the present moment, being unbeatable in rapidly changing situations. And some are bastions of stability and care, putting authority and rules above everything else – the safe keepers of balance books and procedure documents. However, none of these types come close to Analysts, and INTJs in particular, when it becomes necessary to devise a system, to bring many moving parts together, and manage the giant chessboard of opportunities, threats and goals. INTJs' abstract and rational thinking are unmatched in those situations. Your mind is both your greatest gift and your greatest curse – if the environment is right, you will quickly be noticed and appreciated; if it is not, you will get frustrated by all the inefficiencies that you would like to fix and all the problems that you would like to solve. INTJs tend to have many transferable skills, so do not be hesitant to promote them and look for greener pastures if a specific role is not a good match for you and it is not a life-or-death situation (it rarely is).

INTJs are also good at absorbing new knowledge, especially of a technical nature. You are probably already aware of this particular trait, as it becomes clearly visible at school, especially in the later years. Try to use every opportunity you get to learn and experiment with something new, if possible. For instance, many organizations offer various training programs or subscriptions to professional magazines – there is always something else that you can learn. Use that mind of yours as best you can – even if a

particular piece of information does not offer any immediate benefits, it is very likely it will prove useful at some point. You never know when someone will come in and ask if there is a person in the office who has an idea how a certain computer program works or how they should approach a specific project. Life is full of opportunities and INTJs have a major advantage over other personality types when it comes to retaining and categorizing knowledge in their memory. Remember that regardless of what you are doing, you are constantly gaining experience and perspective – and that knowledge is not going to disappear.

Tangentially, it is also worth mentioning that this particular strength can be very useful when it comes to educational qualifications. Regardless of whether you are employed or not at a given time, you may want to consider exploring fields and subjects loosely connected to your main specialization. There are plenty of areas that reward INTJs' strategic thinking and ability to design and work with systems, whatever they may be – keeping your eyes open can sometimes yield great results. Few INTJs can say that they are always satisfied with their roles, so if you are not among the lucky few, trying out a new subject can easily open new horizons and boost your self-confidence as well. You do not necessarily have to get formal qualifications – nowadays, studying independently is easier than ever. Your mind will always be hungry for new knowledge, so why not keep it occupied with meaningful studies as opposed to something that has no lasting value?

If you have an opportunity, you should also try finding a hobby that you could potentially turn into a source of income later on – this approach is quite common among INTJs, especially those in well-paid but not very intellectually challenging positions. The actual earnings do not really matter that much in the beginning – what matters is the chance to do something that truly excites and inspires you, without the constraints of the employer-employee relationship. If you create value – and it is hard not to, if you are truly enjoying what you are doing – other people will quickly notice it and reward you accordingly. This would also tick another very important box in the INTJ's happiness checklist – the desire for independence. It could be anything – a website about your favorite computer game, a local neighborhood initiative, or a small consulting company. Some INTJs want to change the world in some way, others focus on local or personal matters. The main principle is that you should try to do what you truly enjoy, while retaining the safety net of regular employment – and who knows, maybe your idea will be the next “big thing”. If you are also in a position where you can divert some financial resources to your hobby,

then all the better. INTJs tend to be excellent strategists, so you should not have any difficulties managing this parallel “career”.

Remember when I mentioned that your mind is both a gift and a curse at the same time? Here is another thing to consider, building upon the ideas discussed in the previous paragraph – you are bound to overthink things and get bogged down on trying to determine which path is best for you. Try to find time to think and reflect, but do not obsess over details – ironically, INTJs are usually at their best when they are truly relaxed and confident in their skills. If there is one thing you take away from this section, let it be this – it does not really matter which path you are going to take, if there is something about it that you know will keep you going. That path will always be the right one. As an INTJ, you are highly likely to be more knowledgeable and resourceful than the majority of the population – you will be fine. Even if you do not know something, your Intuitive trait will allow you to improvise and your Thinking trait will keep you on the rational path. Think about who you truly are and what you want to achieve in life – and be confident that your skills and knowledge will take you far. Consider self-employment as an example – there are many failed businessmen, but try asking any one of them if they have ever regretted trying. You will be surprised.

Let us go back to the world of offices and cubicles for a moment. Another big problem for most INTJs is going to be personal relationships – people with this personality type rarely care about making friends in the office. Such an attitude is not really surprising – after all, this is their *modus operandi* in many other areas of their life. However, difficulties in developing casual relationships at work can stifle professional development and result in missed opportunities, both personal and professional. It is important to keep your mind open and not cringe at the thought of getting to know your colleagues better – or at least not actively avoiding them.

We are stressing this not only because having connections *will* help you advance your career, regardless of how competent you are – but also because you may find that you are actually a very good leader. INTJs tend to have strong willpower, which, combined with their desire for independence, makes them natural leaders – most people instinctively want to follow the lead of someone who is confident in their opinions. Consequently, you do not need to compromise your integrity in order to be able to influence others. All you need to do is make an effort to establish a connection and some level of mutual trust. If

you are in a role that is a good match for your personality traits (e.g. requires technical and strategic thinking), you will probably notice at some point that most of your non-INTJ colleagues will share a certain sense of both fear and respect when it comes to dealing with you. INTJs tend to have an aura of mystery, and that is easily noticeable – so try not to scare people off even more by being arrogant or condescending. This is a mistake most often made by younger INTJs.

In all likelihood, you will only be satisfied with your career path if you feel confident that it gives you enough intellectual stimulation. INTJs like to set goals for themselves and their thirst for knowledge, regardless of its nature, is unquenchable. Consequently, following a career path that is not really challenging or interesting for you is likely to make you restless and frustrated. Unlike some other personality types, INTJs never actually satisfy their curiosity, and are always looking for new puzzles and refusing to accept unsatisfying answers. Ultimately, everything depends on how flexible your chosen organization is – there are few career paths that are unsuitable for INTJs, but there are plenty of roles that will underutilize your primary skills. So explore, learn and try to find a way to use your strategic thinking skills in that specific field – and do not ever think that the gnawing feeling that you are in the wrong place will pass, if all rational arguments point to the fact that a particular role is unsuitable for you. Neither money nor stability will satisfy you in such a case. INTJs aspire to be wizards – of science, of technology, of nature – seeking to understand and control the unknown and the mysterious. Stability, sensuality or empathy are not their domains.

There are some other things worth mentioning in this section. The first is that INTJs do not fare well in situations where they need to do unfamiliar work under time pressures. People with this personality type are decisive and able to keep a cool head in critical situations, but they feel far more comfortable when they have enough time to assess the situation and make an informed decision. INTJs have an excellent set of leadership skills lurking beneath the surface, but being in “emergency mode” can exhaust them very quickly. Unlike Explorers, Analysts in general are more suited to be planners than frontline executors.

Second, it is important not to underestimate the importance of what is generally called “people skills”. We have touched this topic before, but it bears repeating – social intelligence is just as important, if not more so, than everything else. Many INTJs dismiss this idea, seeing little value in things like small talk

and socializing – but they are also missing the bigger picture. One of the most often repeated complaints is that many people are complacent, easily intimidated and egoistic creatures of habit. It is not a surprise that being as growth-oriented as they are, INTJs are often disappointed by the shallowness and passivity of some people they come in contact with – however, this does not mean that there is no point in learning more about what drives and motivates other members of society. You do not necessarily have to enjoy or to seek deeper meaning in such exercises, but having these skills can give you a tremendous advantage both at work and elsewhere. Sometimes defusing a difficult stakeholder can get you much further than building a system that is twice as efficient as the old one.

Communication between Types

It's useful to have something in common when you begin to talk with someone. It can make the rest of the conversation much more productive if you start with a resounding “yes” rather than stubborn “no”. This section will cover four possible pairings of type groups, including brief overviews of potential synergies and obstacles, as well as some tips that may help you navigate these tricky waters.



Analysts – Analysts

COMMON GROUND

Obviously, two Analysts will find themselves “speaking the same language”. They will both make rational arguments and remain in the theoretical. While facts must play a role when they talk to each other, those will be secondary to the larger ideas.

As puzzle-solvers, Analysts will likely explore systems and concepts, engaging in “what if” discussions with each other. They will share their tendency to improve any system or enterprise they come across. Two with the Analyst’s perspective can be a perfect match for bouncing ideas off each other or brainstorming. Two original thinkers, in collaboration and when they agree, can be a powerful thing.

More than likely, brainstorming among Analysts will be a series of discussions over a long period of time as each will want time to ponder the different facets of an idea.

If they also share the Turbulent trait, both parties will value perfectionism and will insist on it with each other. While this can seem demanding to many, two Analysts will agree that excellence is a worthy goal. (However, they may not agree on how to define “perfect”.)

Two Analysts might quickly agree when there are any inconsistencies in a business or venture. They are both likely to notice the flaws of either a company or its leadership and may form a casual alliance around such matters. While Analysts are impatient with others who make emotional or ideological arguments, this is much less likely to happen between two Analysts. They will share the same contempt for “soft” rationalizations.

Conversations between the two will probably be lofty as small talk would interest neither of them. In fact, they may find each other a relief from the tedium they experience at the water cooler with other types. They will both show an interest in work that has a strong purpose and relevance and are prone to be visionaries. Analysts are likely to connect on this level.

POTENTIAL PROBLEMS

One of the biggest potential problems you may find when you have two Analysts communicating may be competition. Analysts are rare enough that they may not be used to another Analyst in the room, especially one that shares their specific interest. In high school, they were likely unique in their classrooms. University was a shock when they found themselves with other like-minded Analysts. When they enter a career, the competition with any other Analysts could be full on, especially for those drawn to leadership positions. While not prone to drama in an emotional sense, they are stubborn enough to cause workplace turmoil nonetheless. Competition could lead to demanding one’s way.

Analysts are open-minded and easily accept ideas from others as long as they feel those expressing the ideas are competent. However, should they sense incompetence, they can be harsh in their assessment of, not only an idea, but also the person sharing the idea. They often show scorn when people make mistakes or display flawed logic. Analyst character Sheldon Cooper from “The Big Bang Theory” is an

often mentioned archetype for this attitude. And just like his Analyst friends on the program are not immune to his judgmental inclinations, neither are other Analysts in the workplace immune to similar harsh criticism. If they miss a beat, their fellow Analysts will call them on it and perhaps not in the most pleasant manner. While maybe not a dominant feature, Analysts have feelings as well.

Two Analysts can also find themselves in a quagmire of genius if they produce too many great ideas while brainstorming together. They may become trapped in their own cleverness. At some point, they may need to pull in a Sentinel or an Explorer to start weeding out what they can carry out and to harness the brainstorming frenzy. (Mentors have taught writers for years to “Murder their darlings” meaning get rid of the lines and ideas that are favorites but don’t lend to the story. Analysts, at times, may need to kill their darling ideas for the practical good of a business.) Analysts can be stubborn if they sell themselves on their own concepts. Two or more together may be nearly unmovable.

TIPS FOR COMMUNICATING

- You can be comfortable asking the “why” questions and sharing your own observations with another Analyst.
- Give other Analysts space to process material on their own. Don’t be quick to insist on a conclusion to material the other Analyst has not had time to mull over.
- Be aware of any competitive urges that may get in the way of honest and full communication.
- Just because they are also Analysts doesn’t mean they agree with you or that their assessment will always be perfect. Be prepared to display some patience and allow them to prove (or fail to prove) their points in their own time and in their own way.
- Enjoy the productive debate. Most Analysts like intellectual sparring and what better partner than another Analyst? Other types may be too sensitive or set in their opinions. Regard other Analysts as opportunities. They probably are looking for the same. Most Analysts love a challenge to their ideas. Just be careful not to waste too much time at work on the theoretical jousting.
- The Introverted types within the Analyst group may need some encouragement to share ideas even with other Analysts. Encourage them to do so while not demanding it.

Analysts – Diplomats

COMMON GROUND

Diplomats and Analysts both like to work with ideas. Their imaginations manipulate ideas into models. They differ in that Diplomats create ideal designs for a perfect society (or the perfect workforce) and Analysts create ideal schemes for a perfect system. Simply put, Analysts show interest in things while Diplomats show interest in people. While their targets are different, if they can recognize and accept the other's focus while being able to freely share their own contributions to an organization, they may get along well.

Neither Analysts nor Diplomats like many details, both preferring to deal with the “big picture” instead. Both can absorb knowledge almost subconsciously like sponges and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of intuitive understanding. They are both imaginative and creative as they connect the dots, often in deep ways. This likeness of styles and love for the more abstract should give them plenty of common ground and opportunities to combine their talents.

HOW THEY COMPLEMENT ONE ANOTHER

Diplomats live in a world of values and empathy. Analysts are more comfortable with systems and puzzles. Diplomats add to the Analysts' offerings by bringing humanity to their systems. An Analyst working even with a human system like, for example, psychoanalysis will likely allow efficiency to trump empathy every time. A Diplomat can typically provide “soul” to any system that Analysts devise or innovate.

On the other hand, an organization which is only about love, peace and harmony can get a little mushy around the edges. Rational analysis of an organization is an important ingredient needed for it to grow and prosper. This is where Analysts contribute.

POTENTIAL PROBLEMS

While Analysts and Diplomats can certainly use their different focus in complementary ways, this same focus can create points of contention. An Analyst may be critical of a Diplomats point of view and

consider it too soft while a Diplomat may regard an Analyst point of view as without concern for higher values.

As an illustration, let's suppose we have a Diplomat and Analyst trying to decide about an action in a wildlife organization. An Analyst might consider thinning the wildebeest population through hunting as a solution to overpopulation. Overpopulation of any one species will create havoc in an ecosystem. A Diplomat, on the other hand, may value all life as sacred and be reluctant to release hunters on the wildebeest population. The conflict is obvious. But is either wrong? While you want to preserve balance in a wildlife community, you don't necessarily want to be inhumane about it.

Analysts and Diplomats working together will probably spend a significant amount of time debating these different approaches (usually in less dramatic ways) in the workplace. An Analyst manager might argue that it would be more efficient to replace the receptionist at the front desk with a touch screen computer. Computers are cheaper than a continuing salaried employee and can do essentially the same job. A Diplomat manager in the same office will wonder about the welfare of the current receptionist and the lack of human warmth involved in greeting a visitor with a machine. One would highlight the time and money saved while the other would bemoan the sterile approach and the disregard for the employee. It may take some negotiating to resolve such a difference. However, it's hard to say that either perspective is invalid.

Analysts can be brusque and impatient with people who don't see things their way. (Diplomats can feel frustrated and disappointed for the same reason.) The Diplomats' aversion to conflict may cause them to disengage if Analysts come on too strong and if they appear too condescending. However, they might not let it go if they see the Analysts' attitude as an "injustice". If both are aware of these sensitivities, it can go a long to maintaining harmony in the workplace.

TIPS FOR COMMUNICATING

Advice for Analysts concerning Diplomats:

- If you want a heartfelt response, ask Diplomats questions that combine with both "who" and "why" inquiries.

- Try to discover what values are important to the Diplomat. When you discover this, you'll discover what motivates them and that can be helpful in communicating with them.
- Be aware that Diplomats can be acutely sensitive to criticism or harsh words. This can shut them down, at least temporarily.
- Try to compliment or show appreciation, at least occasionally, to Diplomats with whom you work. They respond well to positive regard.

Advice for Diplomats concerning Analysts:

- If you want a heartfelt response, ask Analysts questions that begin with "why". Be willing to explore their view of your organization and what they think it will take to make it run well.
- If you find that you are having trouble communicating with Analysts, don't be afraid to ask them why they think that's the case. They most likely won't be offended and will probably take some time to dissect the interpersonal dynamic between the two of you and will get back to you. It may give you clues as to how to approach them in the future.
- As intelligent as Analysts often are, they are also notorious for lacking emotional intelligence. Be aware of this and try not to take any unfriendly responses or comments too seriously or personally.

Analysts – Sentinels

COMMON GROUND

While they can be complementary (see below), Sentinels and Analysts have few things in common. If there's anything at all, perhaps it's their shared need for efficiency. Analysts work with systems trying to get them to run smoothly. Sentinels do the same with more practical matters.

HOW THEY COMPLEMENT ONE ANOTHER

Sentinels bring order to an organization and see to perform practical tasks. Analysts gain knowledge and assemble the building blocks a system in their minds and on paper. Each plays a different role when they have a job that suits them in an organization. Analysts are visionaries while Sentinels efficiently attend

to business in the here and now. Analysts often ask “what if” and “why” while Sentinels are more likely to ask “how” and expect a tangible answer.

So how do these two different types work with each other and communicate successfully? Analysts sincerely need someone to carry out their vision. They are masters at manipulating ideas but need someone else around to turn their ideas into something practical. Sentinels are great at getting things done. In many ways, that’s a perfect match. A good fictional model might be the visionary CEO with the practical administrative assistant. Think Tony Stark (Robert Downey, Jr.) and Pepper Potts (Gwyneth Paltrow) as comic book caricatures of this in the Iron Man movies. While he busies himself designing his technologies, she keeps Stark Industries running. (From such examples, one might easily think the Sentinel is always subordinate to the visionary Analyst. However, if you consider an Analyst in a research position with a Sentinel boss, you have the opposite power relationship. Yet they complement each other’s roles just the same.)

By clearly understanding and accepting one another’s role and communicating from their positions of strength, each type can become invaluable to the other. Analysts and Sentinels can create a mutually useful and productive partnership in the workplace.

POTENTIAL PROBLEMS

There’s an old saying: “Nobody likes change except a wet baby.” Whole industries have grown up around “change management”. But it’s not true that “nobody likes change.” Intuitive types like Analysts and Diplomats love change. They always look for ideas that improve things. On some level, these types crave it as it represents growth and possibilities to them.

On the other hand, Sentinels focus more on doing the right thing according to proven standards and traditions. With Sentinels, making the status quo work is a priority. Analysts have little regard for the status quo, especially if it gets in the way of improving a system. Sentinels may insist on doing it the “right” way according to how it’s always been done. Meanwhile, Analysts may insist on doing it a “better” way regardless of how it’s always been done.

The universal conflict between those trying to preserve a system and those trying to change it is perhaps as old as man himself. It is an area that can be difficult in the workplace. This can play out as passive-aggressive resistance or discounting the importance of one another's contributions to an organization. These two diverse approaches may need careful communication, reassurances and much understanding.

Analysts' social style can lack warmth and consideration for the emotional needs of others. Sentinels are nurturers and preservers who can be warm with their co-workers. While, they can be rigidly efficient to the point of being controlling sometimes, they keep the welfare of others in mind and they can be extremely loyal. Sentinels would do well not to take an Analyst's criticisms too personally whether it's directed at themselves or others. Analyst would do well to understand that Sentinels may react badly to harsh comments and off-the-cuff negative comments. Since they are so invested in things running well, Sentinels sometimes take criticism of an organization or others on as their own.

TIPS FOR COMMUNICATING

Advice for Analysts concerning Sentinels:

- Make an effort to show appreciation for what Sentinels do. They will not necessarily seek gratitude from others for what they do, but they become energized when they get it.
- Talk to Sentinels about any changes to a system. Understand that their first impulse is to preserve the status quo. Change may feel like something is out of control for them.
- Avoid unproductive criticism of others when speaking with Sentinels.
- Talk about practical tasks rather than theories if you want to connect with a Sentinel.

Advice for Sentinels concerning Analysts:

- Understand that Analyst co-workers benefit from your attention to detail even if they don't always recognize or seem to appreciate it.
- Try not to take any criticism or harsh comments from an Analyst to heart.
- Don't load Analysts down with too many details that aren't necessary. They may show little interest, and they may not even respond to such information.

Analysts – Explorers

COMMON GROUND

For the Explorers and Analysts, they both like to search for answers. Their style and scope of doing so is different (discussed below). However, if they recognize that they are both looking for a “better and more efficient way” it can make any discussion more productive. If they can grasp that and can tolerate their different approaches, they may find that their motives are alike enough. Bonding by using the things we have in common while learning the value of our differences can go a long way in a business relationship.

HOW THEY COMPLEMENT ONE ANOTHER

While Analysts want to play with ideas and systems, Explorers would rather solve problems in a hands-on fashion. While Analyst may not always see their ideas to the end, it can be hard to get Explorers to wait long enough to check with others before they carry out theirs. Explorers work with the here and now and the practical while Analysts work with overarching systems that are more conceptual than tangible. If you want a real problem solved, there is nobody better than the Explorer. If you want to know how to understand a system, deconstruct it or rebuild it on paper, there is nobody better than the Analyst.

When Analysts and Explorers work together, they need to understand that they are each part of a two-step process. Explorers can put together the pieces needed to make the Analysts’ models work. Analysts are notoriously weak at implementation where the Explorers are strong. However, Explorers sometimes don’t pay enough attention to the big picture as they focus on the details. This can put them out of sync with the vision of an organization’s management and perhaps into some hot water. As long as each realizes they both have good things to stir into the same pot, Explorers and Analysts can create a powerful working relationship.

Consider Apollo 13, the movie and a real life event that brought us the iconic phrase “Houston, we have a problem”, as a metaphor. After a mechanical mishap, three U.S. astronauts were in danger of not making it back to Earth alive in their crippled space capsule. The Analysts can be compared to ground control in Houston who calculated all the numbers and worked out a trajectory. They created a system to get the astronauts home.

However, the Explorers / astronauts were the problem solvers. They did the hands-on work and figured out the details that brought about the swing around the moon which eventually got the capsule home. Communication between ground control and the astronauts was vital to the success of the rescue. Okay, it's not a perfect metaphor. Is there such a thing? Nonetheless, hopefully it demonstrates how the different functions and styles can work together to fulfill the same goal.

POTENTIAL PROBLEMS

An Analyst may become annoyed at the Explorers' focus on details while the Explorer may feel that the Analysts' ideas are too vague and impractical. It can be tempting for Explorers to dismiss Analysts as having their heads in the clouds and not understanding the practical side of anything. On the other hand, Analysts may return the judgment by declaring that Explorers are reckless, have no vision and think too narrowly about things. When either or both refuses to see the value of the other's style, communication is likely to shut down.

Analysts can be condescending if they don't feel someone can play skillfully in their playground of lofty notions and complex systems. They may wrongly react to the Explorers' focus on detail and simply write them off as uninspired. Meanwhile, the Explorers are just as likely to be ignoring the Analysts' "nonsense" as they go ahead and complete their revered solutions. The result is that they aren't talking to each other and that's a pitfall that co-workers should avoid.

TIPS FOR COMMUNICATING

Advice for Analysts concerning Explorers:

- Explorers become bored with topics that are too abstract and theoretical. Don't spend too much time there when speaking with them. Share a quick overview of your ideas and add the facts you know. Then give them the space they need to create a workable implementation. They might surprise you and bring your ideas to life in exciting ways.
- Genius comes in many forms. Keep in mind Explorers often have a different kind of intelligence that relies on details and mastery. While it may be tedious to you, vital results often hinge on their attention to the finer points. Be patient and don't try to force them to work in ways that are foreign to them. Respect their style and allow it to work.

- Approach Explorers with “how” questions if you want a heartfelt response.

Advice for Explorers concerning Analysts:

- Analysts become bored with too many details. They don’t need to line up all the facts like you do. Talk to them about how you think your ideas will affect the larger organization or system. Ask them to give you feedback from that perspective. Such a vantage point can save you from going in a wrong direction – one that you might not even be aware you’re going in. The “long-range view” can be your blind spot, and Analysts can help you with that.
- Don’t be too quick to dismiss the Analysts and their theories. They want an efficient outcome just like you. Try to find common ground here even if the point of doing so isn’t immediately clear. You might be surprised how helpful it can be in the long run.
- Approach Analysts with “why” questions if you want a heartfelt response.

Career Progression

You got that job, settled in and have been an exemplary employee ever since. What now? How can INTJs progress in their careers and what difficulties are they likely to have?

Answers to these questions depend heavily on the field that the INTJ is in. People with this personality type tend to do better in non-managerial roles, becoming knowledgeable and respected subject matter experts rather than senior managers with dozens of subordinates. Many companies have recognized that there are two distinct career progression paths and come up with ways to retain and promote personnel who are not really interested in managerial roles. Large corporations and science/technology companies are naturally better at this, so if you are able to get a job there, it is likely that you will be able to secure promotions without being burdened with supervisory tasks.

However, it is also often possible to progress in a field where achievements are measured by the number of people reporting to you. INTJs, like other Analysts, are very good when it comes to mapping out processes and systems, and it is nearly inevitable that someone with this personality type will come up with ideas and suggestions aimed at improving the efficiency of the business model. Furthermore, their

natural curiosity (some might call it nosiness) leads to INTJs having fingers in many pies and indirectly influencing activities not related to their specific role.

This is one way of being recognized and promoted – as the INTJ gets a better understanding of how the company operates, they can grow their responsibilities without overburdening themselves. This would increase their job security and future prospects as well. However, getting appropriate financial rewards can be a challenge in such situations – many managers are understandably reluctant to grant (or try to justify) a raise without any additional managerial responsibilities, not even talking about situations where raising the INTJ's salary would mean that it would reach or surpass the manager's own salary.

It is also important to remember that a better position does not necessarily come with more freedom. If anything, it can mean more red tape and more supervision. INTJs excel in roles where they are able to come up with solutions that increase the efficiency and value of some kind of output, or where they can grow and be recognized. Ironically, getting promoted can often hinder rather than ease such efforts – sometimes, you may be better off staying in the same role longer, using the time to learn something new and then looking for a better-paid job at a different company. Traditional promotion paths and corporate jockeying are not made for INTJs.

There may be times when getting a promotion is simply unrealistic, either because of the organizational culture that sees little value in the skills that the INTJ can offer, or simply because of the lack of room for growth. Here are some ideas of what INTJs could do – changing the employer is an obvious option, but is it the only one?

Alternative Options

However radical this may seem, you do not need to be employed to live comfortably. We live in an age of possibilities and selling your time to a corporation is not the only way to generate income. INTJs are imaginative, bold individuals, and their ability to make connections between seemingly unrelated things and ideas can be very valuable. So why not try putting some of those ideas into practice and turning them into your own business?

Many people find the notion of self-employment quite scary – however, the times when someone could spend 20+ years working at the same company without worrying about the future are over. Job security and guaranteed prospects are a thing of the past, with the exception of several fields such as military or medicine. Consequently, working for yourself may actually be a more secure and viable option, which also comes with a range of other benefits such as the ability to plan your time, see the tangible results of your work and, obviously, be your own boss. INTJs value freedom, control and independence, and being self-employed would give them an excellent opportunity to enjoy these things.

Furthermore, self-employment solves one of the major hurdles that INTJs are likely to encounter in the corporate environment – forced interaction with other people. As a self-employed individual, you are free to choose which tasks you want to perform and which ones you want to delegate or outsource – no more following orders, doing tedious administrative work or dealing with people who are unable or unwilling to improve. Self-employment offers many major benefits to INTJs, especially in today's global and always-connected environment, and people with this personality type are highly likely to be successful in this area.

However, there is no point in trying to start a business without a good idea. This is where the INTJs' ability to come up with unusual connections starts to shine. Anyone could think of a product that could be shipped from the East and sold in the West – but it takes a very imaginative mind to come up with an idea, product or solution that could grow into an innovative business venture. After all, there is a reason why Google and Facebook were developed by geeks in their basements and dorm rooms rather than engineers working 9-5 at multinational companies. Think of an interesting way to fulfill an existing need (or create one) and do not be afraid to experiment. INTJs can be excellent entrepreneurs, having both the imagination necessary to develop a good business model, and the willpower to keep going in difficult times.

Suitable Careers

Let's look at some specific jobs that INTJs may find fit them the best. We do not try to offer a full list of professions. That would be impossible and the list would grow daily. We offer a sampling of jobs that

are consistent with INTJ personality traits with added explanations of why they are. Use this to create guidelines when thinking about your own career goals.

For those of you already employed, this may serve as a confirmation or an explanation for why you might be happy or unhappy where you are. We do not presume this to be a firm prescription of what you must do to be successful or happy. Rather, we hope it will provide you with some insight as you make your personal decisions.

Strategy

It's no accident that we call those with the INTJ personality type Analysts. INTJs explore systems by mentally taking them apart, learning all they contain and then rebuilding them in a more useful way, adding and subtracting to and from them as necessary. Calling this section "Strategy" is cheating a little bit. All INTJs do is strategic in some fashion, but not all strategic jobs neatly fit into categories. So this section serves as a catch-all.

What do these jobs have in common? They all have the potential for having problems that need solving and a need for developing strategies. And that's what INTJs do best.

- Business administrator
- Management consultant
- Project management
- Military officer
- Educational consultant
- Investment analyst

Engineering and Design

Engineering and design are broad categories for disciplines that use science, math, design techniques and ingenuity to create a machine, a structure or a system. They not only create new products, but they remove flaws from old products. Such work can be challenging and conquering such challenges is what INTJs live for. They are particular about which details they pay attention to and may disregard some that others see as important.

However, if certain details are clearly relevant to the final product and the bigger picture, INTJs will embrace those enthusiastically. The details must pass the INTJs' internal relevancy test. Most engineers and designers labor alone over a drafting table, a computer or a work bench a good deal of the time, and this will satisfy the INTJs' "lone wolf" natures. Some jobs that might appeal them include:

- Computer programmer
- Engineering of any type
- Architect
- Inventor
- Environmental planner
- Urban planner

Research / Science

INTJs are passionate in their need to discover how everything works. Not only do they love the discovery, but they are fond of the patterns that often reveal themselves in research. They will take the initiative to explore that which no one has explored before or find a different approach to old research.

INTJ researchers and scientists admire others with similar drive and abilities and can collaborate if they feel they are dealing with equals. Otherwise, they may be better off working on their own. Fortunately, a science or research position does not usually require much social connection. Some of the jobs in this category include:

- Academic researcher / professor
- Physical scientist
- Life scientist
- Astronomer
- Medical researcher
- Physicist
- Psychological research
- Chemist

Medicine

In the medical field, INTJs make thorough diagnosticians and practitioners. What they may lack in bedside manner, they make up for in competency. Their Intuitive trait will allow INTJ physicians to quickly assess a constellation of symptoms and to draw an accurate diagnosis. The choosing of an effective treatment will get the same “big picture” approach. Any of the following fields are full of potential medical puzzles to solve and would be satisfying to INTJs who are so inclined.

- Psychiatrist
- Pathologist
- Neurologist
- Pharmacologist
- Cardiologist

What Would Make a Job Unsuitable for an INTJ?

In modern society, we not only spend a great deal of time at work, but we also tend to allow our work to give us meaning. We need to be careful not to get stuck in a situation that doesn't suit us unless we risk all manner of difficulties. Here are some characteristics of the type of jobs that may not be suitable for INTJs.

Restrictive Environment

INTJs like to experiment and explore new ideas. If the structure and the rules of the workplace are too rigid, they will more than likely feel stifled and unfulfilled. They are passionate puzzle-solvers and are not happy when restrictions keep them from exercising passion. INTJs may not even be able to function at their highest capacity in such an environment.

Too many standards and too much oversight will make INTJs' focus too narrow for the way they process information and gain insights. People with this personality type need room to “play” mentally. To function at their fullest, INTJs need independence, not supervision. They may also reject feeling locked into a career path that seems to be “pre-set”. They are typically happy just doing the work they are passionate about and office politics are annoying to them.

Work that is too dependent on “face time”

INTJs tend to do much better as lone workers. First, they often feel others get in their way. They sometimes see others as an obstacle and a distraction. Second, they can be sarcastic and condescending to those they consider less than their equals. This can create an unpleasant work environment and damage morale. And like any Introverted type, working with others for too long will exhaust INTJs.

Workplace Habits

Most of us will spend a huge percentage of our life at work. This is why we believe that discussing how different personality types behave in the workplace is important. What drives them or makes them miserable? How can you create a mutually beneficial and productive relationship with a specific personality type? How should you handle conflicts with them? Different positions create different perspectives, and how you interact with the INTJ personality in the workplace should reflect this – what works best with a subordinate or colleague may backfire in the presence of a supervisor.

INTJ Colleagues

- Fiercely independent at work, people with the INTJ personality type are “lone wolves”
- Love challenges, especially if they get complete responsibility
- Prefer working alone, mostly because they believe that others are only going to slow them down
- Enjoy brainstorming in the workplace, as long as the discussion does not descend into arguments over details
- Have perfectionist tendencies and very rarely give up
- Cannot stand inefficiency or colleagues who refuse to use more efficient methods
- Loathe manual work, especially where it can be automated
- See little point in networking, socializing or small talk at work
- Intensely private and likely to deflect personal questions
- Very sarcastic and highly likely to make fun (in their own minds) of less insightful colleagues by making them read between the lines
- Dislike phone calls and prefer e-mail instead

- Brilliant masterminds and analysts, able to recognize various undercurrents and tension between certain colleagues in the workplace and avoid them (INTJs are unlikely to use this knowledge to their advantage though)
- Extremely judgmental—people with the INTJ personality type are likely to have very little respect for colleagues they believe are incompetent

INTJ Managers

- Have very high standards when it comes to professional competence
- Willing to give their subordinates a lot of freedom at work
- Casual and relaxed, valuing independent thinking more than protocol
- Despise schmoozing or attempts to manipulate—this will not work on an INTJ
- Likely to treat subordinates as equals
- Respect people with strong opinions, even if they contradict their own views—as long as arguments are non-emotional
- More interested in strategy than tactical implementation
- Strive for efficiency in the workplace—do not take the risk of telling an INTJ manager that you have always done things this way
- Highly respect and reward initiative
- Do not mind being proven wrong if someone else's argument is better
- Will not get involved in office gossip or socializing

INTJ Subordinates

- Only respect the manager if they are actually competent—titles mean nothing to someone with an INTJ personality
- Have no problems criticizing their manager's statements if they believe the manager is intelligent enough to reconsider their position if proven wrong. Beware of a quiet INTJ during the brainstorming session; it is quite unlikely that they have nothing to say. The more likely explanation is that they do not respect you enough to bother airing their opinions.
- Accept and actually enjoy criticism at work, as long as it is followed by valid arguments

- Unlike most other personality types, INTJs rarely see managerial positions as desirable; they would rather be well-paid experts. People with this personality type are unlikely to be a threat to their managers from this perspective.
- May become frustrated when not given enough freedom at work
- Are likely to strongly resist attempts to pigeon-hole them into specific, well-defined roles

What Do Other INTJs Say?

It is one thing to read the description of your type – it is quite another to get tips and advice from fellow INTJs. This is what other INTJs say about their chosen career paths:

“I am a student working in the field of chemical engineering, specifically oil and gas production. If I work hard to adjust to this type of work environment and manage the aspects of my personality, I believe I could do very well in this field.”

“My path was Military /Electrical Engineering. I am now retired and working as a military consultant. Dream job: system design. Why? Because it is fulfilling.”

“I am currently a Physics student. I plan to be an Astro- or Theoretical Physicist. I currently run a marketing/advertising company, until my degree is completed. It is my dream to be a physicist because I like to know how things work. I contemplate the universe, life, and the human experience on a daily basis. Theoretical physics gives me a perspective that you cannot possibly get from any other place. I want answers, if there are really any.”

“I am a Fashion Photographer, because I like inventing, I like aesthetic, and I am passionate for fashion.”

“For the past 7 years I have been working as a mix between a seasonal innkeeper and an executive housekeeper depending on the locations. I am currently looking into becoming ISO certified to be a quality director in the housekeeping/hospitality field. Then I am considering becoming a homeopathic consultant. I would definitely consider this a dream job! Being an innkeeper at inns that were open for only a few months gave me the ability to travel and explore different places on my own while having the financial support to be on my own. At work, as an innkeeper I had the responsibility to take care of everything from running to the coop to get eggs for breakfast, herbs for tea, checking guests in, selling weddings, accounts payable and receivable, super detailed work and customer

service. It was a place for me to excel and raise my standards as well as to deliver my level of preference. As an executive housekeeper, I still get to have the freedom of traveling, but I am expected to stay longer than a few months - which is why I want to get into consultation and quality instead, but all the same, I am given the freedom to wander through the hotels and I am responsible for the presentation, look and quality of the hotels image. I do lead a team, but I find that a lot of my work is best done when I am working individually with the housekeepers in their rooms, where they can see that I am not as impersonal as I can seem to be. This career choice gives me an entire hotels housekeeping operation to look for ways to be more efficient and organized - both things I pride myself on being. I love coming up with new systems and looking for ways to make it more fun for the staff, as well as encouraging them to grow in whatever it is they want to do with their lives, no matter how much the hotel needs them, I tell them that they need to work for their best interests. It also give me the ability to be alone in a room where I can spend hours thinking while I clean and dance around. The last reason why ... there will always be a need for executive housekeepers, all over the world and if I can speak the language, I can work there."

"I am a research specialist in a molecular biology lab. I have never had one single dream job but I do very much enjoy this job as I get to work independently doing meaningful tasks that involve planning, troubleshooting, streamlining, and brainstorming for the future of the facility."

"I am a self-employed translator and editor. My career was not exactly chosen in the sense of predetermining what would be the best option for me and going for it. I ended up becoming it or rather transforming myself into it in part because it was the most logical way for me to make money and fulfill my inner needs. However, as it happens, it is actually a pretty satisfying job for me on many levels. Calling it a dream job may be overstating the case a little, but self-employment is definitely the right option for me. I do not think I could tolerate working for anyone else."

"I chose a career path in the media industry. At the moment, I am working as an in-house copywriter in an international college. My job allows me to deal with the marketing aspects of writing while working with an online marketing specialist and a designer. This is not exactly my dream job. But it is close enough. My dream job is to be a book writer. But I can accomplish that once I find the time to. I am happy in a job that allows me to write daily."

"I began as a lab scientist, then went into teaching those lab courses, then got an advanced degree in computers, and now I install lab software and train users - beta testing the product - very detail

oriented! This is now my dream job - teaching people about software and testing the software - my perfect combination."

"I organize and incorporate social service and educational non-profits, focusing on programs and services, not management level. I work as an independent contractor and this is my dream job because it allows me the benefit of problem solving for the good of people. I am social welfare oriented in the extreme and this is a good fit. It keeps me from getting bored, which I would be if I was the executive director or I was a program manager day to day."

"I am studying accounting and I am on an internship as a financial analyst. I like it because the market is always changing and I have to adapt do new possibilities and try to find out how each company will perform in the future."

"I am an engineer, an applied analyst and a systems designer. I am doing humanitarian work at the moment."

"I work as an interior design project manager - specifically designing high end hotels. I work hand-in-hand with architects, engineers, and developers to implement the design of the hotel. I often joke that I am not a designer, but that I am a problem solver."

"I am a historian. Why? Because I love history and believe we can only create a better future if we understand how the present is made."

"I am a medical doctor, specializing in emergency medicine. This is my dream job because I can handle stressful situations and I enjoy controlling them."

"I work as a computer systems analyst. Worked with a variety of companies from insurance to distribution to financial management. The analysis part suited me, but I was not too keen on design. Logical thinking and breaking down things into components does not necessarily lead to creative thinking and putting components together back into a unitary whole."

"I trade the currency market (Dollar, Yen, Euro, etc.) from home. I would say this is my dream job because it stimulates both my analytical and creative sides. I have to analyze charts and perform technical and fundamental analysis, but creating trading systems requires a lot of independent, creative, and "outside the box" thinking. You have to be a contrarian, be decisive, stand by your decisions, and stay calm. Trading is very structured too, there are certain things that you do not do, ever, unless you want to end up like Bear Stearns or AIG (unfortunately much of Wall Street does

not get this, even after 2008). It also allows me a great deal of freedom from the boring old norm. I don't have to deal with a boss, work place drama/politics, favoritism, worrying about being laid off, fired, or reprimanded, etc. It allows me to essentially opt out of pretty much anything I don't like, and the pay is a lot better. Now for the other side: I also love what I do because the income allows me to give back to society more than I would otherwise be able to. I am very altruistic, and I donate money to non-profits that feed and educate children in third world countries, save animals in China, provide disaster relief, and by giving money to the rolling debt jubilee. I believe that people who "have", have a moral duty to help others who have it rough, and to try and help them help themselves."

"I am a construction project manager. This is my dream job as I manage 4-5 projects concurrently and at different project phases. The job involves high levels of planning, schedule management, team-building and accountability. I use both proven standard methods but need to constantly adjust for day-to-day problems as they arise."

As you can see, INTJs can be found in a variety of jobs, ranging from translation to fashion photography. It is not the role itself that matters, but the INTJ's ability to use their imagination and efficiency-oriented strategic thinking skills. There are fields that are more INTJ-friendly than others (e.g. science, technology or engineering), but people with this personality type can carve out their niche anywhere, if the circumstances are right and they are willing to put in the effort.

All contents copyright © 2014 by MentiScore Solutions Limited. All rights reserved. This document is intended for personal use only and no part of it may be translated, shared, reproduced or transmitted in any form, by any means (electronic, photocopying, recording, or otherwise) without the prior written permission of the publisher.

The publisher has used its best efforts in preparing this document, and the information provided herein is provided "as is." MentiScore Solutions Limited makes no representation or warranties with respect to the accuracy or completeness of the contents of this document and specifically disclaims any implied warranties of merchantability or fitness for any particular purpose and shall in no event be liable for any loss of profit or any other damage, including but not limited to special, incidental, consequential, or other damages.

The information in this document is educational in nature, is provided only as general information, and is not psychological advice. Transmission of this information is not intended to create, and receipt does not constitute a psychologist-client relationship. Furthermore, this information is not intended to be used to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease or psychological disorder.

If you have downloaded this document from a source other than <http://www.16personalities.com> or <http://www.mentiscore.com>, please kindly delete it and contact us by using the form at <http://www.16personalities.com/contact-us> (you can do so anonymously).